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THE WEEK

THE BEST OF THE U.S. AND INTERNATIONAL MEDIA

The AI tsunami

Will it wipe out most white-collar jobs?

Pages 17 and 25



FEBRUARY 27, 2026
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B.



A.

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An anti-ICE protest in Minneapolis (Pages 4 and 6)

Editor's letter

Over the past few months, thoughts of what my children might do when they grow up have been increasingly replaced with worries about whether there will be anything left for them to do. Artificial intelligence is advancing at such a rapid clip that barely a day goes by without news of some too-clever bot gobbling up yet another career path. In this week's issue alone, we have stories on how AI is consuming coding jobs and other white-collar work (see Talking Points, p.17), the panic in Hollywood caused by a new AI tool that with a two-sentence prompt can create cinematic scenes starring replicas of A-list actors (see Film, p.25), and chatbots being recruited for military planning (see Business News, p.32). If all the professions threatened by AI go "poof," how will our children and grandchildren—or any of us—make a living? Before you answer "Learn a trade," first watch a few YouTube videos of AI-powered humanoid robots learning to wield tools in a frighteningly efficient manner.

Perhaps the AI jobs apocalypse will not come to pass, and perhaps new and previously unthought-of lines of work will spring into existence, just as they did in past industrial revolutions. (Color me skeptical, because AI will surely just learn to do those jobs as well.) But I suspect that in the next few years, a growing number of people who have seen AI evaporate their careers or render their kid's degree useless will call for some version of a "Butlerian Jihad." That's the name of a galactic crusade that science fiction writer Frank Herbert stitched into the backstory of his *Dune* series, in which humans rise up against "thinking machines" and build a new civilization based on the credo "Thou shalt not make a machine in the likeness of a human mind." In the real world, such an uprising is unlikely: Nations are too invested in the AI arms race, and by the time enough ordinary citizens are shouting "Stop!" the bots may well be smarter than us and ready to slap down humanity. So what will my teenagers do when they grow up? I don't know—but I'd advise that they act respectfully toward their AI overlords.

Theunis Bates
Editor-in-chief

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No end in sight for Homeland Security shutdown

What happened

The White House rejected a proposed package of immigration-enforcement reforms from Democratic lawmakers this week, as both sides dug in for a prolonged fight over a funding bill needed to reopen the Department of Homeland Security. The department shut down on Feb. 14 after Senate Democrats united in opposition to a funding bill that needed nine of their votes to pass. In exchange for their support, Democrats demanded restrictions on federal immigration agents engaged in an enforcement blitz that has roiled cities and sparked national outrage after the fatal shooting of protesters Renée Good and Alex Pretti in Minneapolis. Democrats' demands include a ban on agents wearing masks, requirements for judicial warrants to enter homes, and an end to racial profiling. "These are commonsense" proposals, said Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer, adding that Immigration and Customs Enforcement had become "a rogue agency."



Some federal agents remain in Minneapolis.

White House border czar Tom Homan, who last week announced a drawdown of the enforcement operation in Minneapolis (see Controversy, p.6), dismissed some of the Democrats' demands as "just unreasonable." He denied that agents engage in racial profiling, saying they make stops "based on reasonable suspicion." Homan said that while he doesn't like masks, agents need to shield their identities, citing an "8,000% increase" in threats. President Trump expressed willingness to negotiate with Democrats, but said his administration is "going to protect ICE."

Meanwhile, federal prosecutors dropped a case against two Venezuelan men charged with assaulting ICE agents in Minneapolis in January. The agents claimed Julio Cesar Sosa-Celis and Alfredo Alejandro Aljorna assaulted them with a broom and shovel, forcing them to open fire in self-defense; Sosa-Celis was hit in the leg. DHS Secretary Kristi Noem accused the Venezuelans of an "attempted murder." But acting ICE director Todd Lyons said video evidence showed the agents had made "false statements." Both men had been placed on leave, he said, and could face termination and prosecution after an investigation is completed.

What the columnists said

The partial government shutdown isn't going to end anytime soon, said **Laura Weiss** in *Punchbowl News*. The Democratic base has long hounded party leaders to fight ICE's impunity; after Good and Pretti's deaths "that pressure increased exponentially." Buoyed by poll figures showing sizable majorities of Americans back ICE reforms—72% in an NBC News poll—Democrats see a "moral and political need to take a stand." Meanwhile, the White House believes the worst of the blowback has passed, and "immigration hardliners" are pushing the administration to stand firm.

ICE is increasingly "lawless" and must be reeled in, said *The New York Times* in an editorial. Agents are trampling on

citizens' basic rights, including the First Amendment right to free speech and assembly and the Fourth Amendment prohibition against unreasonable searches. Instead of restraining them, the administration is shielding lawbreakers from consequences. It has set the nation on "a dangerous course in which the tactics now used against a few may ultimately be wielded against many more."

The "stunning" reversal of the case against the Venezuelans "fits into a larger pattern," said **Emma Tucker** in *CNN.com*. After other shootings, the admin-

istration also backed agents whose accounts later proved false or misleading. That happened with Good and Pretti, who were falsely smeared as "terrorist" aggressors. And it happened in the case of Marimar Martinez, a Chicago woman shot five times by an agent who claimed she'd rammed his vehicle with her car; evidence suggests the opposite happened. In this latest case, an attorney for the Venezuelan men said that not only were the agents never attacked, they shot through a closed front door, after one of the men—routed while working as a DoorDash driver—fled into his home.

Homan's claims about spiking aggression against agents are "deceptive," said **Joe Lancaster** in *Reason*. The government's own numbers show that assaults against ICE officers went from 10 in the first six months of 2024 to 79 last year, when there were five times the number of agents on the street. And most of the supposed assaults were "minor scuffles" during arrests. That can't justify letting a law enforcement agency "operate completely anonymously." As it resists unmasking officers, DHS is trying to unmask ICE critics, said **Olivia Ralph** in the *Daily Beast*. It was revealed last week that the department has sent hundreds of subpoenas to Google, Meta, and other tech firms seeking the personal data of people "behind social media accounts that track or criticize the agency."

Some of Democrats' demands are fair, like outfitting officers with bodycams, said the *Washington Examiner*. But others are "completely unreasonable"—including a demand to cease enforcement near "sensitive locations" such as schools, churches, and courthouses. Given the number of such places in a city, in practice that would mean "a ban on all immigration enforcement."

Most of the demands should be beyond debate, said **Radley Balko** in his *Substack* newsletter. "All but a few are *already the law*, and most of the others are either long-standing norms in U.S. policing or the foundational principles of any free society." No masked, secret police. No beating and arresting protesters or killing them "with impunity." It's astounding that "Republican leaders have sunk so far into the MAGA abyss that they have declared these demands to be 'non-starters.'" The stakes here are "existential," and Democrats must drive home the message that "the Constitution is not a bargaining chip."

What next?

In the near term, Americans are "unlikely to feel any shutdown pain," said **Al Weaver** in *The Hill*. Congress has already passed 11 of 12 funding bills for 2026, so the current fight affects only DHS. And because of billions allotted in last year's spending bill, immigration enforcement will continue. Air traffic controllers are funded, and about 90% of DHS's 260,000 employees—including 95% of Transportation Security Administration workers—are "deemed essential" and must work without pay during a shutdown. If it drags on and TSA employees start calling in sick, Americans could see travel disruptions. But for now "there will be little interruption to services." That's one more reason the standoff is likely to drag on, said **Ed Kilgore** in *New York* magazine. Pressure may mount over the long haul, but for now, the shutdown is "like the proverbial tree that falls in the forest that no one can hear other than the small critters crushed beneath it."

...and How They Were Covered

DOJ tries to close the book on Epstein files

What happened

Democratic and Republican lawmakers this week rejected the Justice Department's contention that it had released all its files on Jeffrey Epstein as required by law, while new revelations from the documents spurred more resignations from high-profile people connected to the convicted sex offender. Following a combative hearing on Capitol Hill last week, Attorney General Pam Bondi sent a letter to Congress saying her department had complied with the Epstein Files Transparency Act and would not make any more material public. She attached a list of 300 famous names mentioned in the files, ranging from the Obamas and Clintons to Elvis Presley, with no context to indicate why the names were there. Rep. Ro Khanna (D-Calif.), who co-wrote the transparency act with Rep. Thomas Massie (R-Ky.), accused the DOJ of "purposefully muddying the waters on who was a predator and who was mentioned in an email" by listing names like Janis Joplin, who died when Epstein was 17.



Massie, Khanna: Demanding more

Billionaire Thomas Pritzker stepped down as executive chairman of Hyatt Hotels this week after files showed he stayed in regular contact with Epstein after the financier's 2008 conviction for soliciting a minor for sex. The documents also brought former Obama administration lawyer Kathy Ruemmler's long-standing friendship with Epstein to light; she announced she would leave her post as Goldman Sachs' general counsel. Yet President Trump, who is referenced hundreds of thousands of times in the files, stuck by his commerce secretary, Howard Lutnick, even though Lutnick was shown to have visited Epstein's private Caribbean island in 2012 after earlier claiming to have cut ties. In a show of support, Trump brought Lutnick aboard Air Force One with him to visit troops at North Carolina's Fort Bragg.

What the columnists said

Bondi's performance during last week's hearing was unprofessional and disrespectful, said *The New York Times* in an editorial. The attorney general "sneered" when "offered the opportunity to apologize" to some of the women Epstein abused—women sitting directly behind her. And she lobbed "schoolyard taunts" at lawmakers, calling one a "washed-up loser." To avoid answering a question, she boasted that the Dow had topped 50,000. Bondi's DOJ has only exposed the victims "to further humiliation while shielding the powerful behind a wall of redactions."

Those redactions didn't protect everyone, said Aidan McLaughlin in *Vanity Fair*. Steve Bannon, who developed a "disturbingly close friendship" with Epstein before the latter's death by suicide in prison in 2019, is all over the files. While the documents haven't implicated him in criminal wrongdoing, they show that Bannon enlisted Epstein's help in his international "crusade against globalism"—in one exchange Bannon vowed to "take down" Pope Francis—and that he advised Epstein on how to rehabilitate his reputation. "First we need to push back on the lies," Bannon wrote in one message. "Then crush the pedo/trafficking narrative; then rebuild your image as a philanthropist."

Bannon deserves opprobrium, said Noah Rothman in *National Review*. But the Epstein saga is fast becoming "a classic moral panic." Massie and Khanna have prioritized "emotional reasoning over logic" in their haste to finger perpetrators, showing no regard for presumption of innocence. To take just one example, said Joe Burn in the *New York Post*, Khanna "dramatically read off six names" he claimed belonged to "wealthy, powerful men that the DOJ hid." In fact, "four of them were just regular dudes who have absolutely nothing to do with the dead pedophile financier."

Still, enough slime has been exposed that even the MAGA faithful want answers, said Christian Paz in *Vox*. Joe Rogan, the massively popular podcaster who helped deliver Trump young male voters, recently called the DOJ's obfuscations the "gaslightiest gaslighting shit I've ever heard in my life." He's not alone. Pollsters say young male voters strongly disapprove of the president's "opposition to the full release of the Epstein files."

What else would you expect from this White House? asked Aaron Regunberg in *The New Republic*. Under Trump, the GOP has focused on helping the "wealthy and well-connected"—like Epstein, his cronies, and Trump himself—evade "justice for their crimes." Republican lawmakers have been working to "shield pesticide makers from liability" when their products cause cancer, and the Trump administration has filed "multiple legally unhinged lawsuits" to try to stop states from making fossil fuel companies pay for pollution. Trump's GOP now runs on a single issue: "elite impunity." As Massie put it this week, Trump is "still in with the Epstein class. This is the Epstein administration."

It wasn't all bad

■ Larry the cat this week celebrated his 15th year as the U.K.'s official chief mouser to the prime minister. Found as a stray, the gray-and-white tabby was adopted from a shelter in 2011 by then-Prime Minister David Cameron, who gave him a home in the official 10 Downing Street residence. Larry has greeted world leaders there ever since, outlasting Cameron and four of his successors. His approval rating is "very high," said Cambridge historian Philip Howell. "He represents stability, and that's at a premium."

■ U.S. bobsledder Elana Meyers Taylor, 41, made history in Italy this week, becoming the oldest athlete to win an individual gold medal in any Winter Olympics when she beat Germany's Laura Nolte by 0.04 seconds in the women's monobob. Meyers Taylor has competed in every Winter Games since 2010, and this was



Meyers Taylor

her sixth medal overall but her first gold. Her teammate Kaillie Humphries, 40, claimed bronze. Ahead of the event, Meyers Taylor said she taught her two deaf sons some new signs. "We went over what 'champion' is," she said, as well as "gold." It's not her first time setting records: In 2022 she became the most decorated Black Winter Olympian in Team USA history.

■ Eleven-year-old Touren Pope was fossil hunting with his grandparents in southwest Wyoming last month when he spotted what appeared to be a fossilized turtle shell. Because they were on Bureau of Land Management land, the family left the find in place to alert authorities. When experts returned to the site, they quickly confirmed it was a complete specimen of a softshell turtle, roughly around 50 million years old. Pope, who wants to be a paleontologist, not only joined the excavation team in the field, he also got to name the turtle, dubbing it "Little Timmy."

Controversy of the Week

Minneapolis: What did ICE accomplish?

The people of Minneapolis just handed President Trump the “biggest political humiliation” of his second term, said Erika D. Smith in *Bloomberg*. Border czar Tom Homan last week announced the end of Operation Metro Surge and a “significant drawdown” of the masked ICE and Border Patrol agents whose thuggish, trigger-happy tactics traumatized the city and left two U.S. citizens dead. Homan did his best to “save face,” citing 4,000 undocumented migrants detained, and touting a new agreement with local jails to assist in deportations. But city officials deny any deal,



Homan: Overseeing the exit

and it took 3,000 federal agents two months to arrest those 4,000 immigrants, at an estimated cost of about \$50,000 a detainee. Metro Surge “was a failure by every metric” said Zeeshan Aleem in *MS.now*. On its first “test drive,” Trump’s fledgling “secret police force” was defeated by citizens armed with smartphones and whistles. And the brutal scenes captured by bystanders—of the killings of protesters Renée Good and Alex Pretti, of people being dragged from their homes and cars, of 5-year-olds being detained—generated some brutal poll numbers. Trump’s approval rating has sunk to about 40%, a plurality of voters say he’s doing a worse job than President Joe Biden, and his approval on immigration is 12 percentage points underwater. For a president once thought to be “unbeatable” on this issue, this could be a turning point.

The “optics” of Metro Surge were a predictable disaster, said *National Review* in an editorial. The theory was that a muscular show of force in Minneapolis would persuade illegal immigrants nationwide “to self-deport.” But a “broader audience” of Americans was also watching, and they sided with civilians over the agents in camouflage. The operation needed more focus and discipline, and

the “no-nonsense” Homan—who recently took over in Minnesota from buffoonish Border Patrol commander Greg Bovino—could have supplied it. But to “throw in the towel” like this, handing a win to leftist “agitators,” sets an awful precedent that will hamstring future efforts to enforce immigration laws.

ICE *did* accomplish its mission in Minneapolis, said Larry Lee in the Fort Wayne, Ind., *Journal Gazette*. As with Trump’s deployment of the National Guard to Los Angeles and Chicago, the “real purpose” of Metro

Surge was to “normalize” the presence of troops in U.S. cities, and to “scare away” nonwhite citizens who might otherwise head to the polls in the midterms. Trump ally Steve Bannon has said openly that the plan is “to have ICE surround the polls in November,” said Paul Blumenthal in *HuffPost*. That’s probably bluster, but ICE has already “spread enough fear and chaos to terrorize” many members of minority communities into staying home on Election Day.

If Metro Surge was a ploy “to scare citizens out of voting,” said Nick Catoggio in *The Dispatch*, it won’t work. Every viral video of agents tear-gassing children and demanding Americans show their papers was a de facto “campaign commercial for Democrats.” Come November, minority voters are more likely to “show up in numbers to signal their defiance” than to stay home in fear. “We still have three years left in Trump’s second term, and his descent into madness will continue,” said Peter Wehner in *The Atlantic*. But thanks to the “brave patriots of Minneapolis,” who refused to take the bait of constant provocations, “we have the beginnings of a road map to help us withstand the Trump assault” on our communities, our democracy, and the essential goodness of America.

Only in America

■ A Chicago-area man is suing an animal sanctuary for the return of his “emotional support hog.” Kenneth Mayle says he acquired Chief Wiggum as a piglet in 2016 and surrendered him to the Chubby Goat Acres sanctuary while experiencing “temporary housing difficulties” in 2018. Those difficulties have been resolved, says Mayle, yet Chubby Goat allegedly refuses to return the now 330-pound hog, which Mayle says was trained to provide “therapeutic benefits, including massage therapy.”

■ A proposed bill in Tennessee would make it illegal for landlords to “livestream” the evictions of tenants. Rep. Antonio Parkinson says he was alerted to the practice when the landlord of an 84-year-old constituent broadcast what turned out to be her wrongful eviction on social media. Eviction is “a very traumatic moment,” says Parkinson. Those livestreaming the process are “exploiting individuals who are at their lowest.”

Good week for:

Going to the videotape, after Sweden’s Olympic curling team claimed Canada’s Marc Kennedy was caught on camera releasing and then touching a stone in violation of the rules. Officials said video replay cannot be used in the sport, in which athletes police their own throws. In response to the cheating allegation, Kennedy told the Swedes, “F--- off.”

Telling your story, after Mike Lindell, the election-denying pillow tycoon and Trump ally running to be Minnesota governor, spent \$187,000 of his campaign funds buying copies of his own autobiography. Lindell says that distributing the books to voters will give him an edge over rival candidates who are “just giving out a little flyer.”

Subtweeting, after former president George W. Bush published a President’s Day essay praising the many virtues of George Washington, including his “self-control,” “modesty,” and lack of “selfish ambition.”

Bad week for:

Sliding sports, after athlete villages for the Milan-Cortina Winter Olympics ran out of free condoms in three days, forcing organizers to promise a restock. “I think 10,000 have been used,” said Olympic spokesman Mark Adams, “2,800 athletes. You can go figure, as they say.”

Perfection, after Italy’s state broadcaster used a digitally altered version of Leonardo da Vinci’s iconic “Vitruvian Man” drawing, a study of ideal human proportions, in the opening credits of its Winter Olympics coverage. Opposition lawmakers demanded Culture Minister Alessandro Giuli “shed full light” on the decision to modify “an absolute masterpiece” by removing its genitals.

Germ theory, after Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. told podcaster Theo Von that he was never really worried about contracting Covid during the pandemic. “I’m not scared of a germ,” Kennedy explained. “I used to snort cocaine off of toilet seats.”

In other news

Pentagon purge deepens

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth last week intensified his purge of military leaders whose views don’t align with his own, forcing the ouster of the Army’s public affairs chief, Col. David Butler, who had been recommended for promotion to general. It’s highly unusual for a defense secretary to meddle in such personnel matters. But Butler was a senior military adviser to Army Secretary Dan Driscoll, and *The Washington Post* reported that Hegseth is jealous of Driscoll’s rising profile within the Trump administration—including his involvement in ongoing Ukraine peace talks. Since Hegseth became defense secretary, the Pentagon has lost more than a dozen top officers through firings or resignations, including the Navy chief of staff, the Air Force chief of staff, the head of the Coast Guard, the head of the Defense Intelligence Agency, the head of U.S. Cyber Command, and the admiral who ran Navy SEALs operations.

The U.S. at a Glance



Chicago

Jesse Jackson dies:

The Rev. Jesse Jackson, pillar of the civil rights movement and two-time presidential candidate known for his impassioned, booming sermons and populist message, died peacefully at his home in Chicago this week. He was 84. Jackson worked alongside Rev. Martin Luther King Jr., joining marches and sit-ins, including the 1965 Selma-to-Montgomery march, before founding the social justice organization Rainbow PUSH Coalition in 1971. In 1984 and 1988 he unsuccessfully sought the Democratic presidential nomination with a progressive platform and stirring slogan—"Keep hope alive!"—that won him 18% and 29% of delegates, respectively. His moral authority and global fame made him a prominent hostage negotiator, winning the release of Americans in Syria, Lebanon, and Iraq. Since 2015, Jackson had been suffering from a rare neurological disorder that made it difficult for him to move and speak. A full obituary will appear in *The Week's* next issue.

Icon of civil rights

Tucson

Few clues in Guthrie case:

The search for *Today* show host Savannah Guthrie's kidnapped 84-year-old mother dragged into a third week as investigators struggled to find leads. DNA on a glove found near the Arizona home of Nancy Guthrie yielded no matches, and authorities said they would cross-check with consumer DNA databases to



Scouring the property

seek possible relatives of the glove owner. Pima County Sheriff Chris Nanos said the family of Nancy Guthrie, 84, had been cleared of suspicion and had been "nothing but cooperative and gracious." Federal agents aiding local officials raided a nearby home last week but turned up nothing. The sole piece of solid evidence remained the footage from Nancy's security camera showing a masked, armed man approaching her home. Investigators are working with Walmart, which sells the Ozark Trail-brand "Hiker Pack" bag the man was carrying, to identify buyers of that product. "It's exhausting, these ups and downs," said Nanos. "But we will keep moving forward."

New York City

Censoring Colbert: Stephen Colbert this week accused CBS of barring him from airing an interview with Texas State Rep. James Talarico—a Democrat who is running for U.S. Senate—out of fear of the Federal Communications Commission. Late-night talk shows have long been exempted from regulations requiring "bona fide news" programs to give equal airtime to competing candidates, but the FCC issued new guidance this year, warning that talk shows could be covered. CBS said it did not ban the Talarico interview, "and presented options for how the equal time" requirement for other candidates in the Democratic primary "could be fulfilled." Accusing the Trump administration of censorship, Colbert posted the interview on YouTube, which is not covered by FCC fairness rules, and it garnered 3 million views in a single day. This administration "wants to silence anyone who says anything bad about Trump on TV," Colbert said, "because all Trump does is watch TV."



Philadelphia

History restored: A federal judge in Pennsylvania this week ordered the National Park Service to restore exhibits on slavery that the Trump administration had removed from the former Philadelphia home of George Washington. The exhibits included placards, video displays, and panels on the nine enslaved people who lived and worked at the President's House site in the 1790s. Park workers took them down to comply with Trump's executive order barring park information that "inappropriately disparages Americans past or living." Judge Cynthia M. Rufe compared the administration's attempt to "assert domain over historical facts" to the Ministry of Truth in George Orwell's *1984*. "Each person who visits the President's House and does not learn of the realities of founding-era slavery receives a false account of this country's history," she said. The Park Service called the ruling an "unnecessary judicial intervention."

Pawtucket, R.I.

Family slaughter: A person with a history of gender dysphoria and making racist and antisemitic comments opened fire at a high school hockey game in Pawtucket this week, killing their son and ex-wife before committing suicide. Police identified the shooter as Robert Dorgan, 56, who also went by Roberta Esposito, and said there appeared to be no conversation or confrontation among the family before Dorgan fired 14 shots, killing Rhonda Dorgan, 52, and Aidan Dorgan, 23, and injuring Rhonda's parents and a family friend. The family had gathered at the Dennis M. Lynch ice rink to watch a younger son play. Police said Dorgan's social media history was littered with racist, pro-Nazi posts frequently referencing "white power." The day before the shooting, Dorgan used an Asian slur when commenting on a video celebrating Hitler. Dorgan had gender reassignment surgery in 2020, and that transition was cited as a cause in the divorce.



Comforting witnesses

Montgomery County, Maryland

FEMA goes in: President Trump this week accused local Democrats of botching the management of a massive sewage spill in the Potomac River—one of the largest such spills in U.S. history. Trump blamed Maryland Gov. Wes Moore and Washington, D.C., Mayor Muriel Bowser for the disaster and said FEMA would take charge of cleanup efforts. More than 200 million gallons of water containing raw human waste poured into the river after a sewer line in Maryland's Montgomery County, about five miles from the U.S. capital, collapsed on Jan. 19. The spill continued for a week before the sewage was diverted to a treatment facility. Drinking water remained safe, because it is taken from a spot upstream, but the river was closed to fishing and boating. Trump said the spill was "a Radical Left caused Environmental Hazard." But Moore said the broken pipe was managed by a utility established by the federal government. "The Trump administration has failed to act," he said, "shirking its responsibility and putting people's health at risk."



Spewing sewage

The World at a Glance



Graham

Munich

Graham loses temper: Sen. Lindsey Graham (R-S.C.) behaved with shocking rudeness last week while meeting with Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen and Greenland Premier Jens-Frederik Nielsen on the sidelines of the Munich Security Conference. According to people in the room, Graham cursed, yawned ostentatiously as Frederiksen spoke, and demeaned her as “little lady” while insisting that President Trump was the most powerful man in the world and would take over Greenland if he felt like it. “Lots of F-bombs,” said one person in attendance at the meeting. “Picture Graham on his worst TV day,” said another person familiar with the encounter. A day before the meeting, Graham had cursed while speaking to CNN’s Christiane Amanpour about Iran, and he told *Politico*: “Who gives a shit who owns Greenland. I don’t.”

Lyon, France

Right-winger beaten to death: A far-right student activist died of his injuries last week after being severely beaten by six masked assailants at a protest by the anti-immigration Nemesi collective. Quentin Deranque, 23, was on the sidelines of the rally against a campus appearance by pro-Palestinian politician Rima Hassan of the far-left France Unbowed party. Police have detained 11 people, including several with links to the outlawed antifascist group Jeune Garde. Far-right leader Marine Le Pen condemned the attackers as “barbarians responsible for a lynching.” President Emmanuel Macron called for calm, saying, “No cause, no ideology justifies killing.” The case has inflamed political divisions ahead of municipal elections next month.



At a rally for Deranque

Havana

Out of gas: Canadians, Russians, and other foreigners left Cuba last week as the energy crisis became so critical that airlines could no longer refuel there. Rotten food has piled up in the streets of Havana, where only 44 of the city’s 106 garbage trucks have enough fuel to operate. Cuba also postponed its annual cigar celebration—the Festival del Habano, normally a huge tourist draw—because of the “complex situation” caused by the U.S. economic blockade. The U.S. has had sanctions on Cuba for over six decades, and President Trump cut off the flow of Venezuelan oil to the island when he removed Venezuelan leader Nicolás Maduro in early January. Trump said the Cuban regime would soon fall and should “make a deal” soon, before the economy collapses. “Cuba is right now a failed nation,” he said.



The pumps have run dry.

Lima

Can’t keep a president: Peru’s Congress impeached President José Jerí this week, just four months after he replaced his impeached predecessor Dina Boluarte, who had replaced the impeached Pedro Castillo. Jerí, 39, is the sixth president to leave office early in a decade, the latest victim of a presidential “curse” that started with the 2000 ouster of Alberto Fujimori for corruption and human rights abuses. Jerí was ousted after he met secretly with Chinese business leaders, triggering an influence-peddling investigation. Caught on video hiding under a hood as he entered a Chinese restaurant for a December meeting with Yang Zhihua, whose company holds government concessions, Jerí apologized for the optics but denied wrongdoing. The scandal became known as “Chifa-gate,” after the term for Peruvian-Chinese cuisine.



Goodbye to Jerí

Oslo

Testing ‘Havana syndrome’: A Norwegian government scientist submitted himself to microwave pulses to prove that such directed energy beams couldn’t cause “Havana syndrome”—only to get debilitating symptoms of the condition, *The Washington Post* reported last week. The results of the 2024 test don’t definitively prove that a secret Russian weapon was behind the mysterious malady that plagued hundreds of U.S. spies and diplomats starting in 2016 in Cuba. While many of the victims reported long-term cognitive challenges and severe dizziness, federal agencies could not agree on what caused the symptoms or whether they were psychosomatic. Still, the test reinforces fears that pulsed-energy devices are a threat. The Pentagon has been examining what they believe is such a Russian device, acquired in late 2024.

Yaoundé, Cameroon

Secret deportations: The Trump administration flew nine people to the impoverished African nation of Cameroon in January under a secret arrangement, *The New York Times* reported last week. None of the men and women were from Cameroon, none had a history of violent crime, and nearly all had been granted U.S. court protections against being returned to their home countries. At least one had lived in the U.S. for 15 years; several had asylum applications pending because they were persecuted for political activity or sexual orientation. The Trump administration has not commented on the deportation, and neither has Cameroon—which has no public agreement with the U.S. to accept deportees. The migrants said they were being held in a detention compound in Yaoundé, and local authorities told them they could not leave.



Crowded quarters

The World at a Glance



Zelensky

Kyiv

Talks collapse: Peace talks between Russia and Ukraine, mediated by the U.S., ended abruptly this week after a two-hour session on the second day, as Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky characterized the negotiations as “difficult.” Just ahead of the talks, Zelensky had expressed a rare rebuke of President Trump, saying it was “unfair” that the U.S. continued to publicly demand major concessions from Ukraine but not Russia. On the ground, Ukraine recently retook territory on its eastern fronts, including the southeastern Zaporizhzhia region, erasing weeks of Russian gains. Ukrainian forces got a boost from SpaceX’s blocking of the Starlink satellite hookups that Russian forces rely on to communicate and to steer drones. A Russian military blogger known as Alexander said a Russian commander once confided that losing Starlink would be devastating, “our Achilles’ heel.”

Moscow

What killed Navalny: Russia almost certainly killed imprisoned opposition leader Alexei Navalny with a rare toxin produced by South American poison dart frogs, five European nations said last week. Samples from Navalny’s body contained traces of epibatidine, a neurotoxin secreted by dart frogs in the wild but not in captivity. “There is no innocent explanation for its presence in Navalny’s body,” governments of the U.K., Sweden, France, the Netherlands, and Germany said. Navalny, an anti-corruption campaigner jailed on trumped-up charges, died in a Siberian penal colony in 2024. French Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot said the case showed that “Vladimir Putin is prepared to use biological weapons against his own people in order to remain in power.” The Kremlin dismissed the claims as propaganda.



He was murdered.

Pyongyang

A daughter to rule: North Korean leader Kim Jong Un, 42, is close to designating his young daughter, Kim Ju Ae, as his political heir, South Korea’s spy agency told lawmakers last week. The dynasty began with Kim’s grandfather Kim Il Sung in 1948, and passed to his father, Kim Jong Il, in 1994, and to Kim himself in 2011. Kim Ju Ae, believed to be age 13, first appeared in public with her father at a missile test four years ago. She has since accompanied him at an increasing number of high-profile events, including a rare trip abroad last September to meet Chinese leader Xi Jinping in Beijing. Intelligence analysts say her visibility indicates she has moved from “successor training” to the “successor-designate stage.” This choice, though, could trigger a succession battle with Kim’s sister Kim Yo Jong, 38, who has assumed increasingly powerful governing roles.



Next dictator?

Dhaka, Bangladesh

New era: Tarique Rahman, son of two famous Bangladeshi leaders, was sworn in as prime minister this week, after returning late last year from 17 years in exile. Rahman, 60, is the leader of the influential Zia family. His father, Ziaur Rahman, was Bangladesh’s president, killed in a military coup in 1981; his mother, Khaleda Zia, in the 1990s became the country’s first female prime minister. Tarique Rahman was jailed on corruption charges in 2007 and later fled to Britain. On his return last year he claimed leadership of the Bangladesh Nationalist Party, which took two-thirds of the seats in last week’s elections. It was the first vote held since the Gen Z-led uprising that toppled Sheikh Hasina’s autocratic government in 2024. Rahman called for a new era of order, saying, “We will not tolerate any kind of chaos.”

Tehran

Show of force: Iran this week temporarily closed the Strait of Hormuz—the waterway through which 20% of the world’s oil passes—for three hours of live-fire drills. The rare military display came as Iranian negotiators were meeting for indirect talks with the U.S. in Geneva. The Pentagon, which already has one aircraft carrier operating in the Persian Gulf region, said it was taking the unprecedented step of sending a second carrier to be ready for military action if the talks collapse. President Trump has threatened punishing military strikes if Iran doesn’t agree to curb its nuclear program, or if it executes any of the thousands of activists who were detained in the protests that were crushed last month. *The Wall Street Journal* revealed this week that the Trump administration had smuggled thousands of Starlink kits into Iran during the protests, to help activists get online after the regime cut the internet.



Iran’s drills in the strait



Israel firing during the Iran war

Tel Aviv

Profiting off military service:

Two Israelis were charged last week with using classified information to place bets on military operations using the Polymarket online prediction platform. The Defense Ministry and the Shin Bet domestic intelligence service said the unidentified suspects, a civilian and a military reservist, placed wagers on future military operations based on the reservist’s inside information. Israel’s public broadcaster Kan had previously reported that a Polymarket user made about \$150,000 off bets on the timing of Israel’s 12-day war with Iran last June. Lawyers for the reservist said their client wasn’t accused of any “serious security offense or negative motive.” But military authorities said that while the misuse of military secrets caused “no operational harm,” it posed a “real security risk” and crossed “a red line.”

Harington's bumpy rehab journey

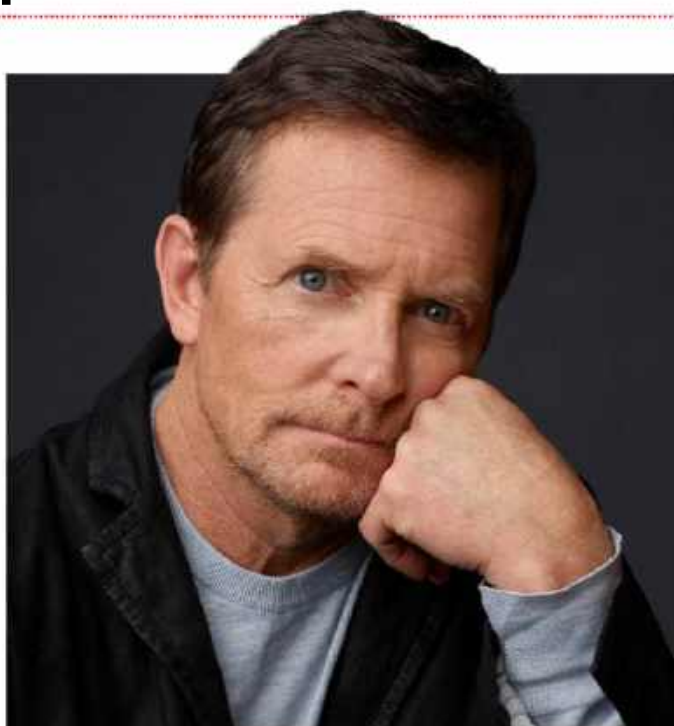


Kit Harington sometimes misses his wild days, said Jeremy Langmead in *The Times* (U.K.), but he knows they weren't sustainable. "Everything in life up until 27 years went so fast, it felt as if the universe was expanding," says the actor, who rocketed to fame playing Jon Snow on *Game of Thrones*. "Then at 28, it just didn't feel like that anymore."

He checked into rehab but didn't stay long. "I just wasn't ready. I knew there was a problem, but I couldn't deal with it." Over the next few years, he realized he had to "grow up" and gave treatment another go. Harington, now 39, was in rehab when the final *Thrones* episode aired in 2019; he still hasn't watched it. "I think I look rather unwell in that final season. I'm struggling with alcohol at that point." He finished his treatment that time, in part because "rehab is so expensive. Every time I thought about [leaving], I'd imagine burning a suitcase with that amount of money in it." The following year, his wife—*Thrones* actress Rose Leslie—became pregnant; they now have two children. "I think it all happened just at the right time. I'd made some choices, and then everything fell into place. I think that my kids met me at the right time; just like my mum did with me and my brother."

The real job of an exorcist

Jason Bray has an unusual sideline, said Abigail Buchanan in *The Telegraph* (U.K.). As well as being an Anglican priest, he is one of the Church of England's deliverance ministers—or exorcists. The role, he says, is not quite as it is portrayed in films. Bray doesn't burst into houses clutching a crucifix: He turns up to fix a problem "like a gas engineer, but for paranormal activity." Called out about a dozen times a year, he works in homes, offices, and stores. In one case, a family had to step over a ghostly "person" with a broken neck who kept appearing at the bottom of their stairs. In another, the individual experienced frequent "jump scares" in the shower from the sight of a deceased relative behind the curtain. Bray also works with mental-health teams to assist people who "believe they are possessed by a demon." Actual possessions are rare, he says. The three signs are "preternatural strength, preternatural knowledge, and knowledge of languages they never learned to speak. So if you were called to a stranger who knew your deepest secrets; attempted to throw the dining table at you; and suddenly spoke in, say, Arabic, there'd be a good chance" of a possession. Such cases might require "a major exorcism." Otherwise, his toolkit consists of a sprinkling of holy water and the Lord's Prayer. "Usually that works."



Fox's fight against Parkinson's shame

Michael J. Fox wants Parkinson's patients and their families to know it's OK to be angry, said Joe Nocera in *The Free Press*. Diagnosed with the disease at 29, the *Back to the Future* star has become the face of Parkinson's for many people, through his charitable work and by living openly and acting with the neurodegenerative condition. "One of the things I'm most happy about is helping take the shame out of having Parkinson's," says Fox, 64. While he's a relentless optimist, he doesn't hide the grim realities of the disease. "I've broken both arms, both shoulders, my face, and a few other things. I still get frustrated. I was always moving, so to not be able to move the way I want to, that's frustrating." Even simple tasks "like walking across the room to get a book off a shelf" require him to get help. Fox is currently guest-starring on the Apple TV show *Shrinking*, and a line his character delivers with defiance, "F--- Parkinson's," has resonated with the community. "My brother, who is 70, wrote me and said, 'Fuck Parkinson's.' Because it's pissed him off too. The thing you have to acknowledge is that Parkinson's is more powerful than you. It's going to have the last word, but you can't be afraid of dealing with it or negotiating around it. I don't have to make it my bully."

In the news

■ **Anderson Cooper** is leaving *60 Minutes* after nearly 20 years as a correspondent, in the latest shake-up to hit CBS News and its storied newsmagazine. Cooper, 58, said this week that he can no longer balance his jobs at CBS and CNN—where he will remain an anchor—with the demands of raising two young sons. "I want to spend as much time with them as possible," he said, "while they still want to spend time with me." But media reporter Oliver Darcy wrote in his Status newsletter that the real reason for Cooper's departure is CBS News' "rightward" turn under the new editor-in-chief, *Free Press* founder Bari Weiss, who stalled several *60 Minutes* investigations into Trump administration policies. Cooper "wasn't



comfortable with the direction the show was taking," said a source, "and is in a position where he doesn't have to put up with it."

■ Team USA's **Ilia Malinin** this week blamed "vile online hatred" for his shock loss in the men's figure skating final at the Winter Olympics. Nicknamed the Quad God for his ability to seemingly defy gravity and land a quadruple axel, Malinin was widely expected to take gold. But he fell twice and finished eighth, the first time in two years that he's missed the top spot. Malinin, 21, told reporters after the event that as he took to the ice, "all the traumatic moments of my life really just started flooding my head." In an Instagram post, the skater said he'd faced "insurmountable pressure" and "vile online hatred" that had pushed his mind "into the darkness." Fans flooded his social

media with supportive messages, with one writing, "Love yourself like we all love you."

■ Hollywood mogul **Casey Wasserman** last week told staff at his talent agency that he was selling the business, because his appearance in the Jeffrey Epstein files had become "a distraction" for the company. In a message to the Wasserman Group's 4,000 employees, he said he regretted his flirtatious correspondence with Epstein's sex-trafficking accomplice Ghislaine Maxwell, in which he asked what it would take to see her "in a tight leather outfit." The messages were sent in the early 2000s, "long before [Maxwell's] horrific crimes came to light," he said. While Wasserman, 51, is not accused of any wrongdoing, more than two dozen of his clients denounced him or cut ties with his firm, including Grammy-winning singer Chappell Roan and retired U.S. soccer star Abby Wambach.

Briefing

Trump's detention empire

As reports mount of abuse and neglect in ICE detention centers, vast new facilities are in the works.

How many people are being held?

As of mid-January, Immigration and Customs Enforcement had some 73,000 people in detention, its highest number ever and an 81% increase from the same point in 2025. The numbers are spiking not only because of the Trump administration's enforcement blitz, but also because of a radical shift away from decades-old policies. People charged with civil immigration violations—such as entering the U.S. unlawfully or overstaying a visa—now face mandatory detention while their cases wind through overtaxed courts. Previously, migrants in this situation would typically be released on bond, especially asylum seekers and those who've lived in the U.S. for years and don't have criminal records. The result of that change is a crush of detainees being kept in more than 200 locations, including county jails, ICE field offices, military sites, and tent facilities such as Florida's notorious "Alligator Alcatraz." The U.S. already had "the largest detention and removal infrastructure of any country in the world," said Doris Meissner of the Migration Policy Institute. "And now it's being put on steroids."



Inside the Baltimore facility

What are conditions like?

Detainees describe a litany of horrors, from extreme overcrowding to physical abuse. "It's like a concentration camp," said Seamus Culleton, an Irish national who's spent five months at Camp East Montana, an ICE facility in El Paso, Texas. A Boston plastering contractor who is married to a U.S. citizen and has applied for a green card, Culleton said he is being held in a cold, damp room with some 70 other men; is constantly hungry because the meals are child-size; and has been allowed outside fewer than a dozen times. It's not just detainees blowing the whistle. A former worker at a Baltimore ICE facility said officers there treated migrants like "animals," with people left "lying in feces" and detainees in overstuffed cells "lying on the floor head to toe." That scene reminded the worker of images "of how they brought the slaves from Africa." Nonprofit groups that focus on human-rights abuses have also produced damning reports on U.S. facilities.

What do they say?

An Amnesty International report on Alligator Alcatraz detailed food contaminated with maggots, sewage seeping into sleeping areas, and insect infestations. At other facilities in Florida, Human Rights Watch documented people sleeping on cold concrete floors, inmates in psychological distress subjected to solitary confinement, and men being forced to eat with their hands shackled behind their backs. "The guards treat you like garbage," said a Colombian detainee. "You feel like your life is over." Numerous reports and lawsuits include allegations of medical neglect, among them the dismissal of serious complaints such as chest pains; at least 32 people died in ICE custody last year, up from 11 in 2024. Six more died in January, including Gerald Lunas Campos, a 55-year-old Cuban immigrant at

Camp East Montana who stopped breathing after a struggle with detention guards. The Trump administration said the guards tried to save Lunas Campos from a suicide attempt; an autopsy report gave the cause of death as homicide by asphyxiation. Despite such reports, the administration is planning to significantly expand its detention capacity.

How many facilities are in the works?

Flush with \$45 billion allocated for new detention centers in last year's spending bill, ICE has in recent weeks bought seven massive warehouses in five states. They include a \$70 million warehouse the size of seven football fields outside Phoenix and a \$119 million, 1.3-million-square-foot former Big Lots distribution center near Harrisburg, Pa., that's expected to house up to 7,500 people. That's nearly double the number of inmates currently held at the largest federal prison. In all, ICE is proposing 23 new sites that together would hold 80,000 people. But fierce local opposition is hampering those plans.

Have any new facilities been blocked?

Protests and political pressure have led some site sellers to back out of deals. "We understand that the conversation around immigration policy is particularly heated," the owners of an Ashland, Va., warehouse said after canceling a federal sale. A firm in Oklahoma City reversed course following a meeting with Republican Mayor David Holt, while the owners of a Salt Lake City warehouse rumored to be in ICE's sights said they had no plans to sell after protests outside their offices. Many opponents of the facilities are motivated by humanitarian concerns; others cite strain on local resources and loss of tax revenue. A mega-detention center planned for Byhalia, Miss., would "foreclose on economic opportunities better suited for this site," Sen. Roger Wicker (R-Miss.) wrote to Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem. An ICE official said such facilities make "communities safer for business owners and customers"; the agency also denies allegations of neglect and abuse at its centers. But critics and detainees say the brutality is real, and a deliberate policy choice.

Children caught in the crackdown

As the number of adult detainees has skyrocketed, so has the number of children held along with them. The detainment in January of 5-year-old Minneapolis boy Liam Conejo Ramos sparked widespread outrage, but "that's very much the norm," said Javier Hidalgo of Texas-based advocacy group RAICES. More than 3,800 children were booked into ICE facilities last year, according to the Marshall Project, many of them at the Dilley, Texas, center where Ramos was held. In court documents, families detained there described moldy food, undrinkable water, medical neglect, and children playing with rocks for lack of other activities. Parents and advocates have reported weight loss, nightmares, and behavior regressions such as children engaging in self-harm. Kelly Vargas, a former New York resident who spent two months at Dilley, said after arriving there her 6-year-old began wetting the bed, crying through the night, and begging to be breastfed. "How are they going to do this to a child?" said Vargas, who in November agreed to be deported to Colombia with her family. "How could this happen here?"

What do they say is the goal?

To deter anyone else who might come to the U.S. unlawfully, and to make those already here self-deport—even if their immigration cases are still working through the system. "They do it so you give up," said Julio Cesar Santos Avalos, who was held at an ICE facility in California City, Calif. Detainees there have complained of being denied insulin and other medications; in a lawsuit, immigrants called the center a "torture chamber." It was too much for Avalos, 47, who suffers from chronic pain due to a foot deformity. Denied pain meds and forced to sleep on a top bunk, he left his two children in California and self-deported to El Salvador, which he last saw at age 7. Some of his former fellow detainees are wrestling with similar choices. "This place," said Cambodian national Sokhean Keo, "is built to break us."

Best Columns: The U.S.

Trump's pagan worldview

Leighton Woodhouse
The New York Times

The Trump administration has rejected “the values of Christianity” and adopted paganism, said Leighton Woodhouse. In the ancient world, the Greeks and Romans believed that “the strong do what they can, and the weak suffer what they must,” as Thucydides put it. Donald Trump’s deputy chief of staff, Stephen Miller, recently echoed this pagan worldview. “You can talk about international niceties,” he said, but “we live in a real world that is governed by strength, that is governed by force, that is governed by power.” The naive “niceties” Miller dismissed are the moral center of the Judeo-Christian tradition. Christianity was revolutionary because “it taught that all humans are God’s creation. To oppress *any* person, even a slave, is an offense before him.” Indeed, “the *weak* are closer to God than the rich and the powerful.” Trump and his allies emphatically reject Christ’s teachings. By extorting Venezuela for its oil, by threatening to annex Greenland and attack even our allies, they are acting like the ancient Greeks or barbarian tribes—“without shame or apology.” ICE’s violent immigration crusade also repudiates Christian values. For this amoral strongman government, Thucydides’ famous aphorism describes “the world they wish to make.”

The election raid based on ‘ZebraDuck’

Elie Honig
New York

The FBI’s recent raid on a Fulton County, Georgia, elections office “was even worse than it seemed,” said Elie Honig. The seizure of hundreds of thousands of 2020 ballots was a “blunt force” effort to “manifest” President Trump’s “exhausting, delusional” claims of a stolen election. When a federal judge last week ordered the Justice Department to unseal its search-warrant affidavit, the pretext for the raid was “somewhere between *dubious* and *nuts*.” The affidavit states that Trump’s team learned of “duplicate ballots” from an “unnamed ‘data analyst’” who found some unspecified, secondhand data from an internet source called ZebraDuck. That’s right: “The FBI forcibly entered a county elections office” based on secondhand information found online. The affidavit also reveals that the investigation “originated from a referral sent by Kurt Olsen,” Trump’s former campaign lawyer and “a dogged 2020 election denier.” His wild theories about 2020 election fraud have been “found ‘not viable’” by Trump’s own DOJ. What’s more, the “FBI never alleges that *any actual person* committed *any actual crime*,” such as intentionally mishandling or miscounting ballots. This bogus investigation was “political score settling masquerading as criminal enforcement.”

MAGA’s schism on Zionism

Andrew Egger
The Bulwark

Donald Trump’s MAGA coalition is being torn apart by an ugly battle between “the antisemites” and “the Zionists,” said Andrew Egger. The schism was on full display at the Presidential Religious Liberty Commission’s recent hearing on antisemitism. Commissioner Carrie Prejean Boller, a right-wing Catholic and strident anti-Zionist, asked commissioners, “If I don’t support the political state of Israel, am I an antisemite, yes or no?” Chairman Dan Patrick of Texas, a Trump supporter, tried to silence Prejean Boller by taking her off the commission. She insisted that “only the president can remove me.” Prejean Boller is part of a loud right-wing faction that includes commentators Candace Owens and Tucker Carlson, who spew vitriolic antisemitism while criticizing Israel’s war in Gaza. They portray Israel as evil and even demonic and claim that Israeli leaders control the U.S. government—an old antisemitic trope. Trump and Vice President JD Vance have refused to renounce right-wing antisemites but also want to keep pro-Israel Christian evangelicals in the GOP tent. That’s not viable: The “philosemites and antisemites are unlikely to share a political coalition for long.”

Viewpoint

“A kind of post-ironic fatalism that was once endemic to seedy message boards [like 4chan] has bled into the broader culture. Nihilism is now the lingua franca of the internet. The 4chan logic that turned even the most hideous news and ideas into empty entertainment pervades everything on the internet now—more proof that *lol, nothing matters*. You can see it everywhere in different forms: In the mass shooters who seem to care about nothing other than performing for others online. In a culture of AI slop and brain rot, and in an administration that prioritizes propaganda and graft over governing. It threatens to rip us apart for good if we let it.”

Charlie Warzel in *The Atlantic*

It must be true... I read it in the tabloids

■ A Los Angeles man who thought he’d boarded a flight to Houston found out he was actually headed to Tokyo. Víctor Calderón, 54, donned his headphones when he sat down and didn’t listen to announcements. After six hours, he asked a flight attendant why the three-hour United flight to Houston was taking so long and then realized his mistake. He turned around in Tokyo and arrived at his destination two days late. The apologetic airline, which was investigating why his original boarding pass was accepted, gave him \$1,000 in travel credits.



■ Frigid temperatures in Estonia have led to the opening of a 12.5-mile “ice road” across the sea linking the country’s two main islands. Officials opened the road after frozen seas halted ferry service and locals spontaneously began driving across the frozen expanse separating Saaremaa and Hiiumaa. Seat belts are forbidden, to allow for a fast exit in case a car crashes through the ice. Hiiumaa Mayor Hergo Tasuja said Estonians enjoy some winter adventure, and that to traverse the icy sea is “in their blood.”

■ A woman in northern England was flummoxed when packages containing random consumer items began arriving at her house—until she realized she’d been online shopping in her sleep. Nicola Edwards, 56, thought she was being pranked by her sister when she was delivered a dog wig, a book on guinea-pig care, ballet shoes, a diamond-tipped drill bit, and dozens of other odd selections. When her husband reported seeing her on her phone in the middle of the night, she figured out what was happening. “I honestly thought I was suffering with dementia,” she said.

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U.S. practiced on us before Venezuela

Editorial
Kaieteur News

You didn't have to be a "palm reader" to see this one coming, said *Kaieteur News* in an editorial. The U.S. ousted Nicolás Maduro just a month ago, and already the new Venezuelan regime has had "enough of the infuriating, humiliating" orders from Washington. Interim President Delcy Rodríguez has told Donald Trump to stop bossing her around, but Trump "is in the driver's seat" and cares only about controlling Venezuela's oil. This kind of shakedown may be new for Venezuela, but Guyana already knows that when smaller countries with tempting resources attempt to resist the U.S., "they do so at their own peril." We have been squeezed like this ever since 2015,

when ExxonMobil discovered vast reserves of high-quality crude in our waters. Under the guise of protecting us from Venezuela, which has tried to take the oil-rich Essequibo territory from us, Washington has taken total control of our oil policy. The U.S. now slurps up almost all of our crude—nearly a million barrels a day. The difference between us and Venezuela is that Caracas is trying to push back against the "smugly arrogant Americans." Our leaders in our own capital of Georgetown, though, "cannot wait for the next order to come." They just "fall in line, with heels kicking smartly," betraying the voters who trusted them and selling out the "wealth of Guyanese for pennies."

CANADA

Don't we want to be a refuge?

Greg Willoughby
Maclean's

U.S. citizens who think they can flee to Canada to escape Donald Trump won't find it easy, said Greg Willoughby. Many of us Canadians are sympathetic, of course: As a refugee lawyer, I'm appalled at the rise in hate speech in the U.S. and at the behavior of the ICE "stormtroopers" who brutalize people "regardless of their citizenship." In the past year, a third of my caseload has become U.S. residents who say they no longer recognize their increasingly authoritarian country. But Canada has changed, too. Its "reputation as a safe haven has unraveled over the last decade." Former prime minister Justin Trudeau, after taking in some

73,000 Syrians from 2015 to 2020, cut refugee admissions sharply, and Mark Carney is cutting them further. American cases are often tossed out on technical grounds, because the U.S. is still categorized as a safe country. And some of my colleagues don't even want to help Americans, saying these people "voted for Trump twice" and are only getting what they deserve. But those escaping Trump's America are likely not Trump voters but minorities that are now finding themselves persecuted: LGBTQ people, Jews, Muslims, dissidents. Ottawa has the power to let them in if it chooses. It's time to decide "what kind of country" we want to be.

China: A death blow to Hong Kong's freedoms

Hong Kong, the last bastion of free speech in China, has now been silenced, said Shen Rongqin in *Ziyou Shibao* (Taiwan). Following Beijing's diktat, a Hong Kong court just sentenced media mogul Jimmy Lai to 20 years in prison on trumped-up charges of conspiring with foreign powers to harm national security. The prison term is "effectively a death sentence" for Lai, who is 78, has diabetes and heart trouble, and is already weak after years of solitary confinement. Of course, Lai "neither conspired with outsiders to rebel nor took action to overthrow the government." All he did was publish *Apple Daily*, the influential newspaper shuttered in 2021 that supported Hong Kong's democracy movement. His true offense was fearlessness. In the pages of his paper, he insulted Communist Party officials linked to the 1989 Tiananmen Square crackdown and openly called President Xi Jinping a dictator. After Hong Kong passed from British to Chinese rule in 1997, Beijing was bound by treaty to continue Hong Kong's liberties guaranteeing a free press, British common law, and fair elections. The crushing of Lai exposes that promise as an "outright lie."

The point of this show trial was to demonstrate to the Chinese people "that dissent will be dealt with mercilessly," said *The Globe and Mail* (Canada) in an editorial. But Beijing would be wise to show some compassion. If it lets Lai "die behind bars," he'll become "an international martyr for the cause of freedom." China is punishing Lai because it knows he's already a hero, said Charles Moore in *The Telegraph* (U.K.). He escaped China as a "penniless child" and flourished in the British colony, which



Lai has been in custody since 2020.

"taught him the difference between tyranny and freedom." He made his fortune in retail clothing and launched *Apple Daily* shortly before the Hong Kong handover, with the slogan, "an apple a day keeps the lies away." Unlike other wealthy tycoons, Lai never "ran away or kowtowed." His writings and courage energized the "huge street protests" against Beijing's 2019 crackdown. A proud British citizen, he believed that the U.K. would hold Beijing to its commitment to preserve Hong Kong's independent courts and free-wheeling press for 50 years.

Instead, "China has trashed both."

And now "times have changed," and Hong Kongers must adapt, said *Ming Pao* (Hong Kong) in an editorial. The media's mission is still "exposing official misdeeds and monitoring the government," yet "press freedom is not absolute." The national security law Beijing imposed on Hong Kong in 2020 has delineated new limits. Journalists are on notice that they may not use their platform as Lai did, as a "tool for political struggle." They will have to try "expanding the space for press freedom" while working within Beijing's new rules. That will be impossible, said the *Indian Express* (India) in an editorial. The Lai case is the "final nail in the coffin" of Hong Kong's democracy movement. It's just further proof that China is growing more repressive and authoritarian. Xi has been rapidly consolidating power, with a "sweeping purge of the military" and the party. He wants his legacy to be an expanded China. "If it is Hong Kong today, it could be Taiwan tomorrow."

Best Columns: Europe

How they see us: Should Europe try to wait out Trump?

There is no “good cop” in the Trump administration, said **Hubert Wetzell** in the *Süddeutsche Zeitung* (Germany). At last year’s annual Munich Security Conference, Vice President JD Vance shocked European leaders with a “sneering, dismissive, and aggressive” foreign policy lecture, saying immigration and restrictions on far-right groups posed a much greater threat to Europe than Russia did. This year, Secretary of State Marco Rubio took a softer tone, purring that the U.S. and Europe “belong together” as avatars of “Western civilization,” and cited a shared love of German beer, Beethoven, and the Beatles. Yet while Rubio got a standing ovation, his message “was by no means fundamentally more moderate” than Vance’s. Rubio, too, painted Europe as a white, “proud, Christian-Western civilization” headed for collapse if it doesn’t follow the Trump administration in lockstep. When even Rubio, considered the one “responsible cabinet member,” spews such MAGA dogma, it’s clear that “America and Europe are now worlds apart.”



Rubio was kind but unyielding with Merz.

Don’t lose faith: “The old America is still there,” said **Max Biederbeck** in *WirtschaftsWoche* (Germany). Two of President Trump’s strongest Democratic critics and possible presidential hopefuls, California Gov. Gavin Newsom and New York Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, also came to the Munich con-fab this year, to reassure Europeans that “things could change back after Trump.” The U.S. president has been a “wrecking ball,” Newsom said, but he will be gone in just three more years. That was what German Chancellor Friedrich Merz needed to hear, said **Elsa Conesa** and **Claire Gatinois** in *Le Monde* (France). The day

before Rubio took the stage, Merz gave a stirring speech rejecting Trump’s “civilizational crusade” and “the culture war waged by the MAGA movement.” Merz hopes to lead Europe toward a “middle ground,” strengthening its independence on security while “maintaining the historical ties that bind it” to the U.S. Such an approach will make a reboot easier once a more normal president takes office.

Yet there might not be much left of the “liberal postwar order” by then, said **Ian Birrell** in *The iPaper* (U.K.). After sanitizing Trump’s agenda, Rubio, the “president’s poodle,” zipped to Budapest “in a show of support” for Prime Minister Viktor Orbán, the most pro-Russian leader in Europe, ahead of Hungary’s April elections. Orbán is the one who created the template for populists that Trump has been following. When he returned to power in 2010, he made Hungary great again through his “scapegoating of refugees, hostility to Muslims,” stifling of the media, “enrichment of cronies, and creeping erosion of democratic checks on power.” That’s why Merz and the others who believe in the restoration of a benevolent Uncle Sam are deluded, said *The Times* (U.K.) in an editorial. “America’s commitment to Europe” can never again be assumed after Trump hit European countries with tariffs and tried to annex Greenland. Listen instead to French President Emmanuel Macron. He says Europe must face the brutal truth that U.S. protection is gone, and it should pour its resources into defending itself and Ukraine. That will be expensive, yes. “But the price of deterrence is lower than the costs of allowing aggressive autocracies to pursue their ends unhindered.”

UNITED KINGDOM

Saving pubs should not be partisan

Jonathan Liew
The Guardian

Nigel Farage says he’s on a mission to “save the great British pub,” said **Jonathan Liew**. Farage, leader of the anti-immigration Reform UK party, is pitching \$4 billion in tax relief for pubs, which would slash a few pennies off the price of a beer. This he would pay for by restoring the two-child benefit cap, a change that would throw 450,000 children back into poverty merely to help subsidize “pints for the lads.” The far-right leader doesn’t seem to care that his math is dodgy and cruel. Like many who attended elite private high schools and colleges, Farage “loves to romanticize the pub as a sort of keyboard shortcut to working-class

authenticity.” Within those wood-paneled walls he imagines an escape from such annoying features of modern society as Muslims and mocktail-quaffing youth. Yet the “real beauty of the British pub is its sheer versatility.” There are “old man pubs,” yes, but also “gay old man pubs,” Desi pubs, “pubs with trans pride flags behind the bar.” Farage is right that the institution is threatened. Pubs are being gobbled up by chains and squeezed by licensing regulations. But saving them is a job not just for crabby old bigots who think tax tweaks can fix anything. It’s for all of us who are “willing to fight for the simple malleable joy of the pub.”

UKRAINE

In defense of our loyal Olympian

Serhiy Marchenko
Espresso

It’s hard for Ukrainian athletes to do “anything patriotic” that criticizes Russia, said **Serhiy Marchenko**. Their athletic regimen is still a legacy of Soviet times, and they train under and alongside Russians. Freestyle skier Oleksandr Abramenko, the only Ukrainian athlete to medal at the last two Olympics, wouldn’t even “unequivocally call Russia an aggressor” when asked by the press. That’s why this year, in Milan, it was so refreshing to see Vladyslav Heraskevych, Ukraine’s sole skeleton racer, take a strong stance against the war by demanding to wear a helmet featuring photos of 24 of the Ukrainian athletes who were killed by invading Russian forces. These were just a sampling:

Russian attacks have killed over 650 Ukrainian athletes and coaches and destroyed 800 sports facilities. The International Olympic Committee bars political protest, so it tried to find a compromise, saying he could wear the helmet for interviews but not competition. When Heraskevych refused, he was disqualified. His teammates have showered him with messages of support, yet what he really needs is for them to follow him in honoring their slaughtered comrades. Disqualifying all 46 Ukrainians “would be a scandal that IOC officials would definitely not want,” and the committee would have to bend. Banning together as a team is how “real athletes do it—one for all and all for one.”

Talking Points

Noted

■ The U.S. military has spent nearly \$3 billion so far on its military operation in and around Venezuela. During the operation's peak—from mid-November to January, when U.S. forces captured Venezuelan president Nicolás Maduro—the price tag exceeded \$20 million a day.
Bloomberg

■ There are now more farmers age 75 and older in the U.S. than farmers under the age of 35, according to the Agriculture Department, partly because many farmers' children are choosing to work in less volatile and more profitable industries. Last year, 315 farms filed for bankruptcy, a 46% rise over the previous year.
The Wall Street Journal



■ The Trump administration has allocated \$15 million from the nation's largely dismantled foreign aid agency, USAID, to pay for security for Russell Vought, the White House budget director and a key architect of the government overhaul that shuttered USAID and cut thousands of federal jobs.
Reuters

■ After 88 years, Gallup will stop tracking presidential approval ratings, the polling firm announced last week, citing a shift in "research goals and priorities." Gallup's Presidential Approval Rating is one of the most respected bellwethers of public opinion on the president's performance. In December, President Trump's approval rating dropped to 36%, one of the lowest Gallup has ever recorded.
The Guardian

Noem: A train wreck tenure at DHS

Kristi Noem is presiding over "an agency in chaos," said Nia Prater in *New York* magazine. That's the image painted by a new *Wall Street Journal* report, in which Department of Homeland Security insiders described how their boss is often at odds with staff, obsessed with her own image, "and entangled with her top



Always camera ready

aide and alleged romantic partner," former Trump campaign adviser Corey Lewandowski. (Both are married and deny rumors of an affair.) There are turf wars: Noem has feuded with border czar Tom Homan, who opposes her ultra-confrontational approach to immigration enforcement, and "routinely berated staff" if she saw him on TV. Upheaval is a constant. Noem and Lewandowski have ousted or demoted 80% of ICE field leadership since arriving. They've also ordered DHS staff suspected of disloyalty to take polygraph tests and kicked out a top ICE lawyer who refused Lewandowski's request for a law-enforcement badge and gun. In one incident, Lewandowski fired a Coast Guard pilot for misplacing Noem's favorite blanket during a plane switch; the pilot was reinstated after the pair realized they couldn't fly themselves home.

This "self-aggrandizing and petty" behavior is costing taxpayers, said Eric Boehm in *Reason*. Noem and Lewandowski have recently been traveling together aboard a \$70 million Boeing 737 MAX

jet, with "a private cabin in the rear." The secretary has also splashed \$200 million on an English-language ad campaign in which she warns undocumented immigrants to "leave now," and an unknown amount on photo ops, posing for the cameras with a rifle, flak jacket, and meticulous makeup. Noem likely

"will not be fired by Trump," said Jeffrey Blehar in *National Review*, because he won't want "a DHS confirmation battle in the Senate with midterms approaching." But Trump has undercut Noem by giving Homan greater control over his immigration crackdown. "Now she limps along in public, like a horse with a shattered leg, waiting only for a dignified moment to be properly put down."

This clown show is "the perfect Trump 2.0 story," said Jacob Weindling in *Jezebel*. Noem and Lewandowski are "unfathomably incompetent." Yet they are responsible for "a true horror": a "genuine ethnic cleansing campaign" in which immigrants are thrown into human warehouses and American protesters are shot dead in the streets. And Noem isn't retreating. Last week, she vowed her agency would make sure only the "right people" voted for the "right leaders" in the midterms. We can chuckle at Blankie-gate, but "we cannot sugarcoat the immense damage" Noem and Lewandowski have done—and will keep doing.

EPA: Blowing up climate regulation

The Trump administration just made its "most audacious anti-environment move yet," said Dharna Noor in *Mother Jones*. EPA administrator Lee Zeldin last week repealed the Obama-era "endangerment finding" that underpins the government's ability "to regulate planet-heating pollution." The 2009 scientific determination found that emissions of carbon dioxide and other greenhouse gases endanger public health and so could be regulated under the Clean Air Act. Now the finding has been scrapped, the EPA is ending emissions standards for cars and trucks, and could soon nix rules for power plants and oil and gas facilities. The EPA claims the revocation "will save taxpayers more than \$1 trillion," said Michael Mann and Bob Ward in the *San Francisco Chronicle*. The reality is that "we'll all pay the price" for this handout to Trump's friends in the fossil fuel industry. Climate-change-fueled extreme weather already costs the U.S. more than \$100 billion a year. Letting polluters pump out more greenhouse gases will only fuel "rising sea levels, intensifying storms, more destructive wildfires, and searing heat waves."

"Climate change is a real problem facing humanity," said *The Washington Post* in an editorial, but we don't need the endangerment finding to fight it.

The U.S.'s share of global greenhouse emissions has been trending down since the end of World War II thanks to our embrace of natural gas and renewables, "which lower electricity prices when adopted for economic reasons rather than because of government mandates." Progressives are in mourning only because they've lost a useful tool to punish disfavored industries, said *The Wall Street Journal*. Both the Obama and Biden teams used the finding to crack down on fossil-fuel-burning cars and power plants. By killing the finding, Zeldin has made sure a future Democratic president won't be able to go even further—"say, by banning petroleum-powered lawn mowers and gas stoves."

The fossil fuel industry could regret its decades-long lobbying campaign against the endangerment finding, said Mark Gongloff in *Bloomberg*. The sector has long argued that states can't regulate emissions because the rule gave that power to Washington. But that protection vanishes with the finding. Bills have already been introduced in California, Hawaii, and New York that would let their attorneys general sue the industry to recoup damages from climate-related disasters. Like Captain Ahab, fossil fuel execs "may find that finally harpooning their white whale risks taking them down with it."

Talking Points

AI: Yes, it's coming for your job

"Humans no longer are—or soon will no longer be—the most intelligent beings on the planet," said Noah Smith in *The Free Press*.

Artificial intelligence has advanced so rapidly over the past year that it's surpassing human intelligence in performing nearly every task. That's the thesis of a viral essay published last week by Matt Shumer, CEO of AI company OthersideAI.

Shumer said the latest AI versions from Claude and ChatGPT—available only through paid subscriptions—are such a major leap that he can give them a complex assignment like creating an app, and voilà! Far faster than any human, the AI will write all the code, create the app, test it, and refine it. Shumer warns that AI may replace half of all white-collar jobs within five years. Critics call Shumer an alarmist, but I suspect he "understates the pace and magnitude of the changes taking place." Like Native Americans who saw sailing ships disgorging European settlers on their shores, we're coming face-to-face with "forces greater and more powerful" than ourselves. We may soon lose control of our destiny—"forever."

AI will certainly be very disruptive to jobs, said James Pethokoukis in *Vox*. But energy capacity and decisions about AI regulation, development,



Will AI soon replace half of all white-collar jobs?

and adoption will "move at ordinary speeds." About 80% of U.S. businesses do not currently use AI, and they won't shift to heavy reliance overnight. Over time, the economy will adapt and shift jobs toward hands-on, human work AI can't do well, such as health care, education, and creative work. Some "urgency may be warranted," but Shumer's "AI apocalypse warning"

of a rapid job wipeout is overly pessimistic.

Still, what "if the doomers are right?" asked Philip Klein in *National Review*. If AI advances so quickly that millions of highly educated, well-paid white-collar workers become not only unemployed but unemployable, "it will be more destabilizing to our politics than anything we have previously experienced." In the worst-case scenario, "elite anger" could fuse with populism and spark "revolutionary fervor that sweeps through the nation and topples the republic." Remember, though: "We get to decide how technology is used," said Jonathan V. Last in *The Bulwark*. Before it's too late, we must "create rules that govern how industries may use AI," just as we regulate so many other endeavors. We don't "have to walk into a dystopian future just because OpenAI builds it."

Vaccines: RFK Jr.'s chilling impact on research

Robert F. Kennedy Jr. has delivered a staggering blow to the vaccine industry, said Jonathan Cohn in *The Bulwark*. Vaccine maker Moderna announced last week that the Food and Drug Administration rejected its request to review a newly developed mRNA flu shot for those over 50, even though a randomized trial of nearly 41,000 people found the shot to be 27% more effective at preventing illness and 49% more effective at preventing hospitalization than existing flu vaccines. This "alarming" decision came from Vinay Prasad, the Kennedy-installed head of the FDA's vaccine and biologics division. The FDA indicated it didn't even consider approving the Moderna vaccine, ostensibly because it objected to how it constructed its trials. The blatant bias against mRNA technology has massive implications: As demonstrated during the Covid pandemic, manufacturers can produce mRNA shots much more quickly than old-fashioned vaccines, typically grown over months inside chicken eggs. During outbreaks of a frequently mutating virus like the seasonal flu, or a new pandemic, that speed is vital.

It's unclear whether Prasad's intervention stemmed from mRNA "paranoia" or Kennedy's "hostility to all vaccines," said the *New York Post* in an

editorial. But the rejection of Moderna's more effective flu vaccine very likely will wind up "killing hundreds, maybe thousands, of senior citizens." In most years, more than 20,000 Americans die of the flu and hundreds of thousands are hospitalized. And "the issue is much bigger than this one shot," said Lisa Jarvis in *Bloomberg*. Drug and vaccine developers "rely on regulatory certainty," as do investors like Blackstone Life Sciences, which put up \$750 million for the Moderna shot. If investors are spooked by the moving federal goalposts and anti-science attitudes, innovation in the U.S. bioscience industry will fizzle even as the field flourishes in other countries, including China.

That corrosive process is already underway, said Rebecca Robbins in *The New York Times*. Moderna laid off 800 workers last year, and "lost more than \$700 million" in federal contracts "to develop a shot to protect humans against bird flu." Work was halted on new vaccines against herpes, shingles, and chickenpox. Venture capital investment into firms developing new mRNA vaccines fell from \$510 million in 2023 to just \$174 million last year. "We have to invest more cautiously," said Peter Kolchinsky, a biotechnology investor in Boston, "if at all."

Wit & Wisdom

"When Nero demanded recognition for his musical talents, it was the beginning of the decline of the Roman empire. Donald Trump's efforts to be awarded the Nobel Peace Prize are similar to Nero's demands."

Polish lawmaker Roman Giertych, quoted in the *Financial Times*

"It's good to do uncomfortable things. It's weight training for life."

Anne Lamott, quoted in *Southern Living*

"Give me leave / To speak my mind, and I will through and through / Cleanse the foul body of the infected world."

William Shakespeare, quoted in *The Globe and Mail (Canada)*

"There is no sincerer love than the love of food."

George Bernard Shaw, quoted in *The Age (Australia)*

"To create a world where old people pity young people is the most perverse and dysfunctional thing."

Irvine Welsh, quoted in *The Times (U.K.)*

"Taxes are what we pay for civilized society."

Oliver Wendell Holmes Jr., quoted in *Bloomberg*

"Nature gives you the face you have at 20; life shapes the face you have at 30; but at 50 you get the face you deserve."

Coco Chanel, quoted in *The Knowledge*

Poll Watch

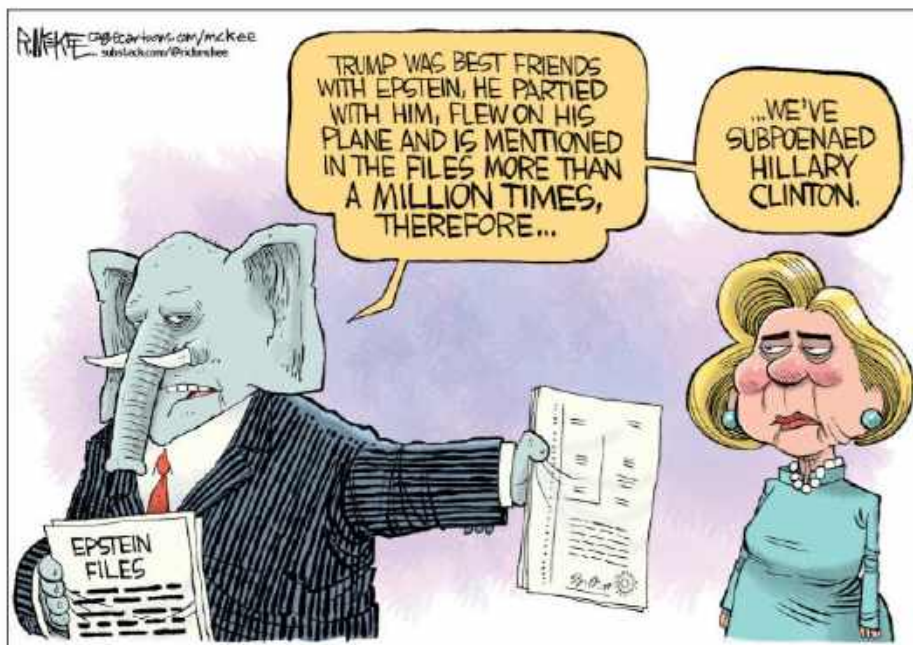
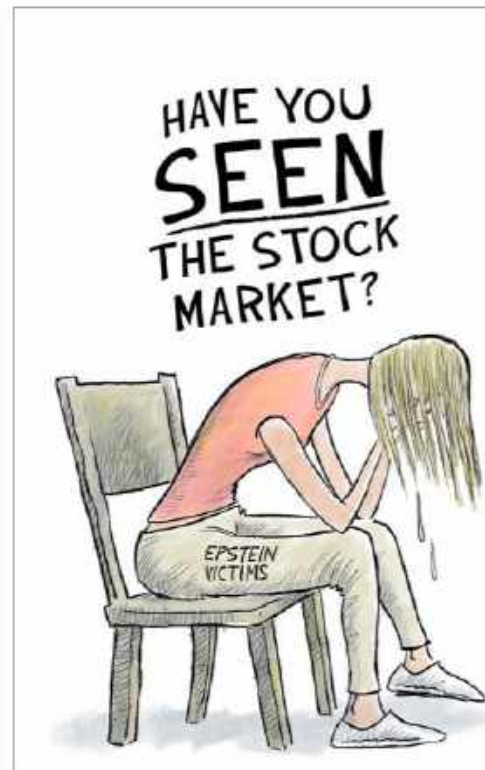
■ **60%** of Americans disapprove of President Trump's handling of immigration and border security, up 9 percentage points since April 2025.

NBC News

■ **50%** of Americans think Donald Trump was involved in Jeffrey Epstein's crimes. **29%** do not think Trump was involved. **85%** agree that "powerful elites" assisted in Epstein's sex-trafficking.

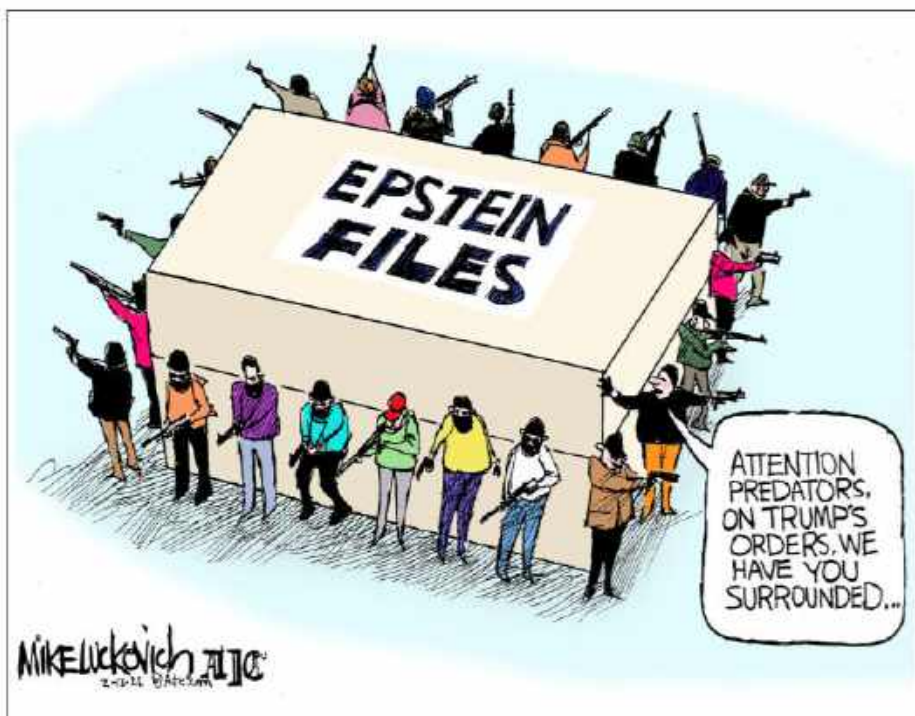
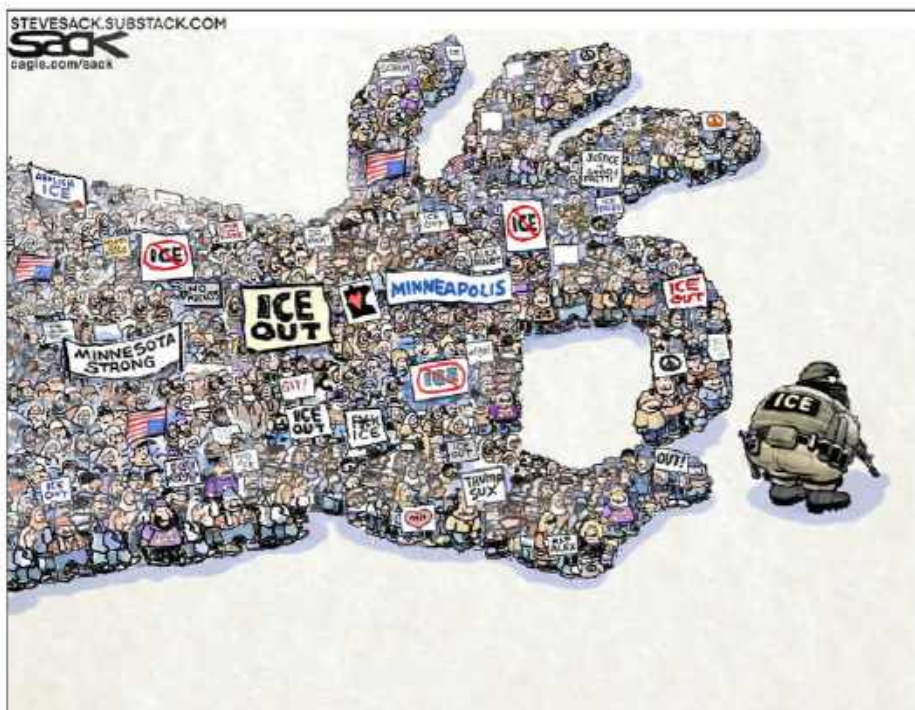
Economist/YouGov

Pick of the Week's Cartoons



Pick of the Week's Cartoons

For more political cartoons, visit:
theweek.com/cartoons



AI: Chatbot answers now come with ads

We've already reached "the beginning of the end of ad-free ChatGPT," said **Madison Mills** in *Axios*. Like the social media companies that came before it, Sam Altman's OpenAI has realized it "has to make money at some point." Last week, the startup officially began testing ads for U.S. users on both its free and lowest-priced subscription tier. The ads that users will see are "shaped by what you're discussing" with the chatbot. Someone researching recipe ideas, for instance, may be shown an ad for a grocery delivery service. The company says it will avoid promoting anything during "sensitive" conversations, like those about mental health or politics; won't show ads to under-18s; and won't share personal data with advertisers. But its decision to introduce ads at all immediately became a "key sticking point" in the AI race.



Altman: What's he selling?

OpenAI rival Anthropic wasted no time seizing on Altman's cash grab, said **Alex Kirshner** in *Slate*. It rolled out a series of ads during the Super Bowl in which a "dead-behind-the-eyes" person representing ChatGPT pivots mid-conversation "into selling something rather than just answering the question." Anthropic has vowed never to place ads on its chatbot, Claude—though Altman not too long ago also said ads would be "a last resort" for OpenAI. "The most interesting thing" about the brewing rift, however, is that it has increasingly become "about what AI should be for in the first place."

Anthropic can sit on its high horse for now, said **Maxwell Zeff** in *Wired*, but ads on ChatGPT were inevitable—and Claude probably isn't far behind it. While both companies offer subscription services, ranging from \$20 a month to \$200, most AI users "never pay a dollar," and bills are adding up. OpenAI has raised \$64 billion from investors but has generated "only a fraction of that" in revenue. And Altman has said it will take a trillion dollars in spending to realize his AI ambitions. He "previously acknowledged the failures of the social media era," including the creation of addictive algorithms that maximized engagement to drive more advertising revenue. Yet Altman now risks repeating the mistakes of Facebook and TikTok.

"AI is expensive to run, and ads can be a critical source of revenue," said **Zoë Hitzig** in *The New York Times*. But I resigned as a researcher at OpenAI last week because I worry that the firm's promise to make sure that ads do not influence outputs will collapse under commercial pressure. ChatGPT has created "an archive of human candor that has no precedent, in part because people believed they were talking to something that had no ulterior agenda." Users have shared "their most private thoughts": medical fears, relationship problems, beliefs about God. "Advertising built on that archive creates a potential for manipulating users in ways we don't have the tools to understand, let alone prevent."

Innovation of the week

Pongbot Pace S Pro is the "best tennis coach I've had," said **Bronwyn Thompson** in *New Atlas*. The AI-powered tennis-ball launcher is about the size of a large suitcase and can hold 150 balls at once, sending "drives, slices, lobs, and drop shots"

at speeds up to 80 mph and with spin rates up to 60 revolutions per second, allowing for "heavy topspin, backspin, and flat shots."

The Pongbot

comes programmed with more than 500 training drills, but players "can also design custom workouts, building personalized sequences that vary speed, spin, placement, and rhythm." Its prime feature, though, is an AI function that "uses player tracking thanks to a wearable sensor," helping the robot detect where the person is positioned so it can dynamically adjust its ball direction.



Bytes: What's new in tech

■ Musk's new moon shot: A lunar city

Elon Musk has told SpaceX employees to concentrate on establishing "a lunar settlement" on the moon before putting humans on Mars, said **Jeff Foust** in *SpaceNews*. "A little more than a year after dismissing the moon as a 'distraction,'" Musk has changed his mind. He wrote on X last week that SpaceX has "shifted focus to building a self-growing city on the moon," something he views as achievable "in less than 10 years." From the moon, he plans to "catapult" satellites into orbit that will form the basis for space-based AI data centers. "Musk said he remains interested in sending humans to Mars," which historically had been one of the company's driving objectives. But traveling there is complicated by the infrequent alignment of the planets—"every 26 months," Musk said—whereas "we can launch to the moon every 10 days."

■ Meta glasses to get facial recognition

Meta is planning to add facial recognition to its smart glasses, said **Kashmir Hill** in *The New York Times*. A proposed feature, called "Name Tag," would let wearers of its Ray-Ban frames "identify people and get information about them via Meta's artificial intelligence assistant." An internal document shows that the company "has been conferring since early last year" on the

project and suggested that "the political tumult in the United States was good timing for the feature's release," because the "civil society groups that we would expect to attack us" would be distracted. Meta first considered adding the feature to glasses in 2021 "but pulled back over technical challenges and ethical concerns." The company paid \$2 billion to settle lawsuits in Illinois and Texas related to its use of facial recognition to "let users tag friends in photos more easily."

■ 'Deleted' footage isn't gone

How did police recover Nancy Guthrie's Nest cam footage? asked **Jennifer Pattison Tuohy** in *The Verge*. The FBI last week released video from the Google Nest doorbell camera at Guthrie's home showing a masked man attempting to cover up the lens. Officials said the missing woman's camera "had been forcibly removed, and she did not have a subscription," meaning nothing was stored in the cloud. But FBI Director **Kash Patel** said investigators recovered the footage using "residual data located in back-end systems." According to Google, "some footage is uploaded and stored" in its servers—typically up to five minutes—whether you pay for a subscription or not. Still, actually locating these files without any identifier "is like searching for a proverbial needle in a haystack"—or a needle in one of Google's massive data centers.

Health & Science

Why scurvy is making a comeback

When British pop star Robbie Williams revealed last year that he had developed scurvy—a “17th-century pirate disease,” as he put it, caused by vitamin C deficiency—it made headlines around the world. Williams had been taking one of the GLP-1 weight-loss drugs, such as Ozempic, Wegovy, or Mounjaro. Now dietitians say his case highlights a broader problem with the drugs, reports the *New York Post*. Researchers looked at all the major clinical trials of GLP-1s, covering more than 40 studies involving 50,000 people over 17 years, and found that just two of these studies had assessed dietary intake—

and only one had published detailed data on what patients were eating. GLP-1 medications are effective because they suppress appetite, but eating far less without nutritional guidance can lead to dangerous deficiencies. Scurvy, for example, can cause bleeding, weakness, and even death; in the 15th century, Portuguese explorer Vasco da Gama lost half his crew to it. “A reduction in body weight does not automatically mean the person is well-nourished or healthy,” says study author Clare Collins, a dietitian from Australia’s Newcastle School of Health Sciences. She recommends that doctors prescribe their weight-loss patients counseling



Half of Vasco da Gama’s crew died of scurvy.

on adequate nutrition. “Let’s get on the front foot,” she says, “and link these chronic management plans to a dietitian referral.”



Quickly find the correct vehicle and road sign.

The game that prevents dementia

A simple computer brain-training game could cut the risk of dementia for decades. Researchers looked at data from the federally funded Advanced Cognitive Training for Independent and Vital Elderly (ACTIVE) trial, which enrolled nearly 3,000 adults age 65 and over who had no significant cognitive impairment. Participants were assigned to trainings on visual speed, memory, or reasoning, about an hour at a time twice a week for five weeks. Half of each group also did follow-up training for three years. Those in the speed training cohort who had completed the follow-up sessions were 25% less likely to develop Alzheimer’s or other dementias over the next 20 years. The other groups showed no correlation. The speed program—a game called *Double Decision*, available from the company Brain HQ—trains users to process visual information more quickly by identifying objects and locations that flash briefly on a screen. New York University neurologist Thomas Wisniewski tells *NBCNews.com* the results are “astonishing,” saying it’s “really the first clear documentation in a randomized controlled trial that at least some form of cognitive training can lower the risk of dementia.”

Obesity and deadly infections

Obesity may be driving far more infectious-disease deaths than previously recognized, reports *The Guardian* (U.K.). Researchers

analyzed data from more than 500,000 Finnish and British adults whose health had been tracked for an average of 13 to 14 years. They found that those with a body mass index of 30 or higher were as much as 70% more likely to be hospitalized or to die from illnesses including flu, pneumonia, urinary tract infections, gastroenteritis, and Covid, compared with those with a healthy BMI (between 18.5 and 24.9). The risk rose with weight. The study team estimates that obesity currently contributes to about 600,000 of the world’s 5.4 million annual infectious-disease deaths, or around 11%. Researchers aren’t sure why obesity makes people more vulnerable to infection, but they suspect it affects the immune system. Lead author Solja Nyberg, an epidemiologist from the University of Helsinki, says the findings suggest the problem will worsen. “As obesity rates are expected to rise,” she says, “so will the number of deaths and hospitalizations from infectious diseases linked to obesity.”

Zap your way to altruism

Could selfishness one day be treated? A new study has found that gently stimulating

the brain with electricity appears to make people behave more altruistically, reports *The Times* (U.K.). Researchers asked 44 volunteers to choose between different ways of splitting sums of money with an anonymous partner. The participants were given an initial ratio, (for example a 74:26 split), followed by a second option, (say 62:38), and were then allowed a few seconds to select the split. During this decision, scientists applied noninvasive electrical stimulation to the frontal and parietal lobes, aiming to synchronize activity between the two regions. When a higher “gamma” frequency (between 40 and 90 Hz) was used, rather than a lower “alpha” frequency (8 to 12 Hz), participants were more likely to choose the more generous option, which gave the stranger a greater share of the haul. The stimulation appeared to nudge the brain toward unselfishness by altering communication within a neural network involved in social decision-making. Co-author Christian Ruff, from the University of Zurich, says the study “sets the stage for future research on cooperation, especially in situations where success depends on people working together.”

Friendship among rival raptors

Birds of prey are not known for being gentle and loving toward other species. But researchers in Texas have documented multiple instances of black vultures grooming crested caracaras, in what appears to be a rare display of cross-species cooperation. The observations stem from two sightings in San Antonio. In one, a black vulture was seen carefully preening a caracara’s head and neck in a city park. In the other, two vultures groomed a pair of caracaras while perching on the roof of a house for around 20 minutes. Such interactions, called “inter-specific allopreening,” have been



Vulture and caracara

documented only a handful of times, reports *The New York Times*, mostly in rural Texas and parts of Central and South America. Some ornithologists suspect the behavior may simply be an instinctive response triggered when one bird lowers its head. Others say that urban green spaces, where different species cluster more densely than usual, have created new opportunities for unlikely alliances. “People think that nature is always about violence and conflict, red in tooth and claw,” says Neil Buckley, a biologist at SUNY Plattsburgh who wasn’t involved in the study. “But actually there’s a lot of collaboration and cooperation.”

Review of Reviews: Books

Book of the week

The Last Kings of Hollywood: Coppola, Lucas, Spielberg, and the Battle for the Soul of American Cinema

by Paul Fischer (Celadon, \$33)

"Paul Fischer's compulsively readable account of how Francis Ford Coppola, George Lucas, and Steven Spielberg changed the world of moviemaking isn't just a group biography," said Chris Vognar in *The Boston Globe*. "It's also a collage of art, commerce, and ego, set against what became a new age of Hollywood blockbusters—an age that this trio did much to create." As the 1960s turned to the '70s, the trio were little more than "brazenly confident" kids eager to make their own movies, with the older Coppola having a slight head start. By 1971, the three were friends and allies. By 1977, they had found paths within a changing industry to making three market-altering hits: *The Godfather*, *Jaws*, and *Star Wars*. Fischer's story of how each got there raises a question that matters in any such field: "What does it mean to sell out?"

"Fischer shrewdly analyzes his trio's individual temperaments," said Wendy Smith in



Coppola, Lucas, and Spielberg in 2007

The Washington Post. In 1969, the manic dreamer Coppola partnered with the loner Lucas to create American Zoetrope, a production company that was supposed to break free of cinematic norms. Lucas shared Coppola's dream of escaping Hollywood's restraints, but he was prioritizing money when he pushed Coppola to say yes to directing *The Godfather*. Meanwhile, his love of comic books and old movie serials made him a more natural partner with Spielberg, with whom he eventually co-created the *Indiana Jones* franchise. Lucas' priorities changed after he made *Star Wars*. Fischer depicts him as becoming the kind of

profit-focused producer he once despised. Coppola, in turn, is depicted as erratic and self-indulgent. Yet "there are no simple people in *The Last Kings of Hollywood*," Fischer's "smart, juicy" account of a transitional moment in American filmmaking.

"At times, one wishes for more characters," said Alexander Larman in *The Spectator* (U.K.). Some of the larger-than-life figures of the era, including Martin Scorsese and Brian De Palma, are "relegated to entertaining walk-on appearances." But by focusing on Coppola, Lucas, and Spielberg as a trio, Fischer "derives a fresh idea from a period that has already been exhaustively studied," said Michael O'Donnell in *The Atlantic*. Instead of showing us that lone visionaries can sometimes triumph, Fischer's account "demonstrates the evergreen value of collaboration." Though at times the three "fought bitterly," they made up easily, provided one another with financial support and constructive criticism, and inspired one another to make better films. The title of Fischer's book suggests that American moviemaking will never have another era as rich as these three knew. But today's ambitious young filmmakers should read the book differently. "Perhaps the artistic fraternity of the '70s is not a relic but a model."

Novel of the week

Eradication

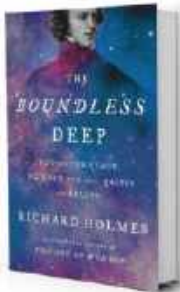
by Jonathan Miles

(Doubleday, \$25)

"Give yourself a day to take in the full effect of *Eradication*," said Ron Charles in *The Washington Post*. "An instant classic" that runs to only 176 pages, the novella tells of a former musician and schoolteacher who has been hired to save the endangered species of a once-Edenic Pacific island by shooting 4,000 goats that are stripping the land bare. As Adi, the protagonist, is ushered to the island, left among his docile targets, and pulls a trigger for the first time, author Jonathan Miles displays "an uncanny ability to create a terrifying kind of momentum." And because Adi was suffering distress already, "there's something almost too intimate about watching this shattered man try to reclaim his purpose through an act of mass murder." Miles' revelation of a tragedy in Adi's past "sharpens and complicates" the story's moral dilemmas, said Matt Bell in *The New York Times*. Those dilemmas, however, are with Adi daily during his island stay. His employers tasked him with eliminating a malignant non-native species. But to save the world, as he would like to, "who or what is the real cancer he should destroy?"

The Boundless Deep: Young Tennyson, Science, and the Crisis of Belief

by Richard Holmes (Pantheon, \$35)



Richard Holmes "specializes in seeing familiar figures from a new slant," said Suzi Feay in the *Financial Times*. In his new book, the British biographer blows the dust off Alfred, Lord Tennyson, helping us see Queen Victoria's favorite poet as "a dashing, compelling, mysteriously conflicted figure." Tennyson, after all, didn't reach national-treasure status, or have the money to marry, until past 40. Before then, he struggled not just to make a living but also to cope with the scientific discoveries of the era that upended prevailing beliefs in humanity's centrality in the universe.

Until his 1850 artistic breakthrough, Tennyson "seemed doomed to loneliness, doubt, and willful eccentricity," said Catherine Nicholson in *The New York Times*. Born in 1809 as the third child of 11, Britain's future poet laureate was raised by a brutal and unstable clergyman father. Tennyson escaped by attending Cambridge, where he

found his first true friend in the dashing Arthur Hallam, who died suddenly at 22 on a trip abroad. Immediately, Tennyson began writing elegies to his friend, which grew across nearly 20 years into *In Memoriam*, the 133-poem collection that won the poet his fame. By focusing on the man who wrote that work, *The Boundless Deep* "invites us to appreciate the remarkable fruits of his protracted estrangement."

Unfortunately, the book's Tennyson "remains an elusive figure," said Kathryn Schulz in *The New Yorker*. And Holmes is "almost mute on an obvious question: Was Tennyson in love with Arthur Hallam?" While it's "lovely" to read Holmes' commentaries on Tennyson's verse, he seems too fixated on the poet's deep engagement with the era's science and with the implications of such discoveries as Earth's relative insignificance, the planet's vast age, and the rise and extinction of its dinosaurs. Still, Holmes writes about the resulting crisis of faith "with such sympathy that even his most secular-minded modern readers feel the shock of finding oneself alone and unloved in a godforsaken universe," said Lucy Hughes-Hallett in *The Guardian*. And when Holmes loves a poem, "he writes about it with a wonderful capacity for noticing every pulse of meter, every flicker of nuance."

The Book List

Best books...chosen by Wil Haygood

Journalist Wil Haygood, who wrote the profile that inspired the 2013 film *The Butler*, is the author of 10 books, including a biography of Thurgood Marshall. His new book, *The War Within a War*, examines Black Americans' experience of the U.S. intervention in Vietnam.



Simple Justice by Richard Kluger (1976). This was the first book I purchased after college. It thrillingly merges historians' craft with journalistic rigor. The portraits of Thurgood Marshall, Charles Hamilton Houston, Jack Greenberg come off the page as Kluger captures the drama behind *Brown v. Board of Ed*, one of the most epochal court battles America has known.

We Are Not Afraid by Seth Cagin and Philip Dray (1988). The 1964 tale of the Freedom Summer volunteers who met on a campus that's now part of Miami University in Ohio, my alma mater, to travel together to Mississippi to help Blacks secure the right to vote. Three of the volunteers—Andrew Goodman, James Chaney, and Michael Schwerner—were killed by white supremacists shortly after arriving in the state.

Team of Rivals by Doris Kearns Goodwin (2005). President Lincoln saved the nation by putting patriotism over rivalries. This is wide-angled history, and given the times in America now, we shall soon see if anyone can emerge to emulate Lincoln's monumental feat.

Arna Bontemps-Langston Hughes Letters 1925-1967 edited by Charles H. Nichols (1980). I'd never seen a collection of letters exchanged by two Black writers whose friendship dated from the Harlem Renaissance to the 1960s. Both men spent long careers invested in Black literature well before the rest of the nation began taking the genre seriously.

The Price of a Ticket by James Baldwin (1985). Little did I know when I interviewed Baldwin upon publication of this career-spanning essay collection that he'd become such a force in my life. He makes appearances in most of my books. His cultural insights about this nation and its inability to "summon our better angels" constitute an eternally timely warning.

The Making of the Atomic Bomb by Richard Rhodes (1986). The dark side of war and human misery come together in this astounding work about the creation and 1945 deployments of the atomic bomb. Page by page, a reader cannot turn away even while knowing the terror that looms ahead.

Also of interest...in paths to artistic success

The School of Night

by Karl Ove Knausgaard (Penguin, \$32)



It's not clear how the fourth novel in Karl Ove Knausgaard's *Morning Star* cycle fits into the larger story, said Charles Arrowsmith in *The Guardian*. The protagonist, Kristian, doesn't even appear to be the same person referenced in earlier books. In this "compellingly nasty" tale, he's a spiteful photographer writing a 500-page suicide note after a career buoyed by a Faustian bargain. Wherever Knausgaard's six-book series ends up, it remains, for now, "an object of fascination."

When We Were Brilliant

by Lynn Cullen (Berkley, \$30)



Lynn Cullen's new novel presents a Marilyn Monroe we've never seen, said Valorie Castellanos Clark in the *Los Angeles Times*. The narrator is legendary photographer Eve Arnold, who frequently photographed Monroe as the two became friends and allies. Cullen's care for the inner lives of both women "shines through on every page." What's more, Arnold is "the perfect lens to view Monroe through because she can show us who Marilyn might have been when there weren't any men around."

A Long Game

by Elizabeth McCracken (Ecco, \$27)



In this idiosyncratic guide to writing fiction, novelist Elizabeth McCracken "offers something better than advice: She gives permission," said Mark Athitakis in *Alta*. McCracken argues that the hardest parts of writing a novel are putting in enough effort to produce a draft and then having the courage to fix what's wrong with it. "Her brand of inspiration isn't cheap uplift, just reports from the trenches about the sorts of things that can waylay a writer, both on the page and in life."

Nothing Random

by Gayle Feldman (Random House, \$40)



Publishing legend Bennett Cerf would have enjoyed this "superb" biography, said Michael Dirda in *The Washington Post*. It reassesses his importance despite "nary a hint of hagiography" and it's "a whole lot of fun." Cerf co-founded Random House, publisher of some of 20th-century lit's biggest names, and his success emerged from the nonstop party he made of his life. Despite Cerf's tireless bonhomie, "readers may find it hard to really like the man." That's how well the book does its job.

Author of the week

Dorothy Roberts

Dorothy Roberts may have just delivered the last word in an argument she'd begun with her father while still in grade school, said **Kate Tuttle** in *The Boston Globe*. Roberts, a 69-year-old scholar who was awarded a 2024 MacArthur "genius" grant, has just published a memoir, *The Mixed Marriage Project*, that also completes a research project



on interracial marriage that her sociologist father worked on for decades. The elder Roberts, who was white, believed

that interracial marriages like his own eventually could bring an end to America's racial caste system, and he conducted hundreds of interviews with interracial Chicago couples while Roberts was young. She remembers pushing back against his optimism about interracial love's revolutionary power. But she admired his research enough that, after his death, she dug into it fully expecting to simply finish the work he'd started.

Certain discoveries startled Roberts, said **Andrea González-Ramírez** in *NYMag.com*. Her father hadn't fallen in love with her mother and then begun his study. He conducted the first interview as a graduate student in 1937. He had also kept project files on his three daughters. "It was a shock," Roberts says. "I first thought, 'Were we guinea pigs to prove his hypothesis that interracial marriage could be successful?'" That idea quickly passed when she recalled how much her father had loved all of them. Still, she understood that her parents' and her own experiences needed to be part of her book. Years ago, she tried to hide that she had a white father. Today, she's grateful for him. "One thing I came to realize," she says, "is how much his deep faith in our common humanity influenced my work and my activism."

Exhibit of the week

Gabriele Münter:
Contours of a WorldGuggenheim New York, New York City,
through April 26

"The time has come for Gabriele Münter's work to be celebrated on its own terms," said **Katie White** in *Artnet*. For too long known mostly as Wassily Kandinsky's long-time mistress, the German-born Münter (1877–1962) "charted a rebellious and wonderful path for a woman of her time." In retrospect, she emerges as "one of the most consequential expressionist painters of the turn of the century," a status reinforced by her participation in 1911–14 as a founding member of the proto-expressionist Blue Rider group. In the current retrospective of her work at the Guggenheim, said **Dian Parker** in *Observer*, "she is not so much rediscovered as finally recognized for what she always was." She was an artist who, despite a tumultuous adult life, "never stopped experimenting," producing paintings as well as striking works in photography, drawing, printmaking, and more.

In the paintings, "her vibrant colors and simplified forms act like gravity, pulling



Münter's 'Snow and Sun' (1911)

in viewers," said **Judith H. Dobrzynski** in *The Wall Street Journal*. And "her choice of homey subjects, unusual angles, or surprising vantage points adds to the tug." In *Still Life on the Tram* (1909–12), we see a potted geranium held by two gloved hands in the lap of its owner, a woman whose face is cropped off by the top of the picture. Münter developed her style while traveling with a camera in hand, then by studying under Kandinsky and traveling with him throughout Europe. During World War I, he fled to Moscow and she fled to Stockholm. After learning he'd married another woman, she returned to a home she'd purchased in the foothills of the Bavarian Alps, lived there with the art historian Johannes

Eichner, and hid in the basement a cache of modernist work, including Kandinsky's, that the Nazis considered "degenerate" art. She also continued showing her command of vibrant color, as in *Snowy Landscape With a Red-Roofed House* (1935) and *The Blue Lake* (1954).

The Guggenheim's show "isn't quite as electrifying" as a larger Münter retrospective that opened almost simultaneously in Madrid, said **Martha Schwendener** in *The New York Times*. The New York show focuses too much on Münter's early work instead of her "breakout" use of color. But some of that later work is here. "And then there are the photographs." Before she ever met Kandinsky, Münter traveled to Missouri, Arkansas, and Texas in 1898–1900, using a mass-market box camera to capture what she saw. One of those black-and-white images, of a young man reading on the floor of his Texas bedroom, "recalls Alfred Stieglitz," while another is a remarkable portrait of three exquisitely dressed Black women gazing steadily at Münter's lens as they walk through Marshall, Texas, on the annual celebration of Emancipation Day. Given Münter's eye, you can't help but think that if she'd stayed in America and kept taking photographs, "the art world might look very different today."

J. Cole
The Fall-Off

★★★★



"In the thick of midlife, J. Cole is reflecting on the legacy he'll leave," said **Rodney Carmichael** in *NPR.com*. His latest release is "less concept album than epic conceit," supposedly a final

statement from a Fayetteville, N.C., rapper who, at 41, is playing at being "an old man, a new man, and everyman all at once." He's still confidant of his membership in the Big Three, alongside Kendrick Lamar and Drake, as one of the great emcees of their era. Yet his attempt to present his as an everyman's hip-hop journey falls flat, especially when he invokes a classic 1994 Common track with "I Love Her Again," repeating Common's "cringe" metaphor of rap as a woman who's slept around. "The sheer sprawl of the record—24 tracks, 100 minutes—is daunting," said **Mark Richardson** in *The Wall Street Journal*. Cole considers the first dozen songs a reflection on his rise, and the next dozen wisdom from an elder. "Bombs in the Ville/Hit the Gas" even imagines his older and younger selves linking on FaceTime. Despite some highlights and sharp writing, the album "starts to feel like a concluding montage that lasts just a bit too long."

Jill Scott
To Whom This May Concern

★★★★



Jill Scott's first album in more than 10 years "pushes her adventurous streak to the fore," said **Mosi Reeves** in *Rolling Stone*. "Dabbling in everything from trip-hop to New Orleans rhythm

& blues," the 53-year-old neo-soul pioneer has made a record that might initially disappoint fans who expect more of Scott's "babymaker R&B anthems." But there are plenty of new treasures to admire, including "Liftin' Me Up," with its "bubbly go-go rhythm," and "Norfolk Side," which finds Scott capably trading rhymes with Tierra Whack over a beat by DJ Premier. "A portrait of a warmly familiar, complex, all-too-human artist," the 19-track record rewards repeated listening. "If there's one universal truth about Scott, it's that she contains multitudes," said **Steven J. Horowitz** in *Variety*. She's both "brassy and contemplative" on *To Whom This May Concern*, at times sitting through the wreckage of two divorces, at other times finding love in unexpected places. She "pulls from all directions here—cocktail jazz, big band, cosmic R&B, even diva disco—yet it all feels distinctly Scott," an "ever-evolving" artist who knows exactly who she is.

Video games: Mewgenics

In the gaming world, "an army of cats just took down Olympus," said **Marloes Valentina Stella** in *Polygon*. Days after its Feb. 10 release, *Mewgenics*, a cartoonish indie game about breeding mutant cats and sending them into combat, had more than 115,000 people playing concurrently on Steam, breaking a record for "roguelike"



games set by 2025 Action Game of the Year *Hades 2*. Though it was 15 years in the making, *Mew-*

genics earned back its budget in three hours and sold a million copies in a week. Despite a "gross-out" aesthetic that will alienate some cat lovers, *Mewgenics* is an "almost endlessly replayable game," said **William Hughes** in *AV Club*. I've cursed it "more than any game in recent memory," mostly because of the "million or so ways" the game punishes inattention, especially by way of the complex mechanics of "kitty-on-kitty violence." *Mewgenics* makes an art form of randomness. "There is randomness in the enemies you face, in the special events that occur between fights," and "most especially" in the abilities of each new generation of cats you breed.

Review of Reviews: Film & Podcasts

Pitt vs. Cruise: The AI clip that shook Hollywood

Forget the Valentine-friendly release of the new *Wuthering Heights*, said Nick Schager in the *Daily Beast*. In Hollywood, “the biggest film of the weekend, and maybe the year, is a 15-second short starring Tom Cruise and Brad Pitt.” The clip seems to show the two stars in a rooftop fistfight, but it was generated by Seedance 2.0, a new AI tool, and it’s “so lifelike that it’s virtually indistinguishable from reality.” The concerned Irish filmmaker who posted it on X said he’d created it with a mere two-sentence prompt. The video went viral when Rhett Reese, a top screenwriter, reposted it along with the following comment, “I hate to say it. It’s likely over for us.”



Seedance’s renderings of the two stars

Chinese tech giant that owns Seedance as well as TikTok. When Hollywood faced a similar scare in late 2025 from an AI video generator created by OpenAI, unions, studios, and talent agencies banded together to push for changes, including the signing of licensing deals. In this case, ByteDance promised within a week of Seedance 2.0’s release to strengthen safeguards against rights infringement before the global rollout of Seedance later this month.

Not everyone was worried by the fake Cruise-Pitt clip or the other star-studded short videos created last week using Seedance, said Derrick Bryson Taylor in *The New York Times*. Rick and Morty writer-producer Heather Anne Campbell said in an interview, “I haven’t seen anything good yet. It’s all just garbage.” But Reese’s comments spread widely, and the co-writer of the *Deadpool* movies held firm to his judgment that Seedance’s technology represents an existential threat to many film careers. “In next to no time,” he said in a post, “one person is going to be able to sit at a computer and create a movie indistinguishable from what Hollywood now releases.”

The reaction from the rest of Hollywood was “swift and fierce,” said Katie Kilkenny in *The Hollywood Reporter*. The Motion Picture Association, representing major studios, and SAG-AFTRA, the actors union, issued harshly worded statements condemning Seedance for its unauthorized use of copyrighted content and of actors’ likenesses. Soon after, both Disney and Paramount sent cease-and-desist letters to ByteDance, the

EPiC: Elvis Presley in Concert

Directed by Baz Luhrmann



“There’s nothing better than observing the greatest artists of all time do what they do best,” said Johnny Oleksinski in the *New York Post*. Elvis Presley has been widely derided since his death for his seven-year run of Las Vegas performances, but Baz Luhrmann’s new concert documentary proves that his early 1970s shows were electric. “What a supreme entertainer Presley was, right till the end.” Luhrmann, who also



The King in his Vegas era

directed the hit 2022 *Elvis* biopic, secured access to 59 hours of 1970s concert film footage, and that trove proves to be “nothing short of unburied treasure.” After a “dazzlingly edited” recap of Presley’s career, the show begins, said Owen Gleiberman in *Variety*. The rock legend, who was just

35 in 1970, was “still incandescent to look at,” and his first-ever live performance of “Burning Love” is “guaranteed to give you chills.” Yes, he often wore gaudy white jumpsuits, but seen today, they “have the glam audacity of true rock ‘n’ roll.” His Vegas era, far from a joke, turns out to be “one of the greatest second acts in history.” Like Luhrmann’s earlier Elvis movie, this one lets its subject off easy, said Radheyen Simonpillai in *The Guardian*. We hear nothing of his abusive behavior as a husband. Nor of his failure as king of a musical genre rooted in Black culture to speak out for Black civil rights. Otherwise, Luhrmann and Presley make a perfect match, “the *Moulin Rouge* director’s razzle-dazzle” being fully in tune with “the singer’s rattle and roll.”

Ruairi Robinson/X Neen

New and notable podcasts

Our Ancestors Were Messy



If this “seriously underrated history podcast” is new to you, let its two-part Black History Month special be your introduction, said *Podcast Review*. The two “elegantly told” episodes focus on Paul Robeson and his actress-anthropologist wife, Eslanda, and “it’s easy to fall for this couple.” Paul is widely remembered as an actor and singer, but he and “Essie” were also globe-hopping civil rights activists from the 1920s through the 1950s, when they became targets of the Red Scare. “This isn’t just a rattling story of the fiery combination of two of the biggest civil rights activists history has seen,” said Lauren Passell in *Podcast the Newsletter*. The story is filled with spies, Cold War-era hysteria, and surprising plot twists. And Hill, with the help of best-selling author Jason Reynolds, “weaves in the juicy details, too,” including Paul’s affairs. We could say we forgot the Robesons, but the truth is they were “purposely erased from history.”

Love + Radio: Blood Memory



This compelling new 10-part series about a convicted murderer “makes you wonder, and waver,” said Miranda Sawyer in *The Observer* (U.K.). Is former prison inmate Michael Lynne Thompson an ethical man who was forced to kill or a manipulator who says what you want to hear? Whatever you find yourself believing at any moment along the way, the podcast is “a great piece of storytelling,” some of that thanks to Thompson and the rest to host and *Love + Radio* creator Nick van der Kolk. Thompson is “certainly complicated,” said Alice Florence Orr in *Podcast Review*. Raised on a tribal reservation, he was convicted in 1973 for the murder of two drug dealers and in prison became a high-ranking member of the Aryan Brotherhood before turning on the gang. Thompson is “seductive” as he describes the harm he’s done, but what are we to do with this information? “Van der Kolk’s answer is clear. We embrace complexity.”

Streaming tips**The Oscar-nominated short films****All the Empty Rooms**

Some of the best documentary shorts in recent years have forced audiences to look in difficult places. This heart-breaking work emerged from two journalists' seven-year effort to visit and photograph the bedrooms left empty by American children killed in school shootings. *Netflix*

Armed Only With a Camera

This vital documentary follows filmmaker and photojournalist Brent Renaud into danger, highlighting his dedication to telling the stories of people caught in the middle of conflict. It doesn't look away when Renaud is killed by Russian soldiers in Ukraine. *HBO Max*

Two People Exchanging Saliva

This unnerving live-action drama takes place in an alternate Paris where kissing is forbidden by law. An extended flirtation between a customer and a department-store clerk peaks in a series of slaps—this society's currency. *YouTube*

Jane Austen's Period Drama

This live-action nominee is a sharp period satire. Just as a young gentleman kneels to propose marriage, Estrogenia Talbot's menstrual blood begins flowing profusely. Her suitor assumes she's dying, leading to hilarious complications. *Kanopy*

Butterfly

A man goes swimming in the ocean, and his mind drifts to memories both pleasant and horrific. This beautiful animated work is based on the life of Alfred Nakache, a French Jewish swimmer who competed in the 1936 Olympics and survived Auschwitz. *YouTube*

Retirement Plan

Domhnall Gleeson narrates this wry but stirring animated short about a man pondering all he aims to do during retirement. The disconnect between his ambitions and his current life makes all too clear that the changes he hopes for will never come. *YouTube*

The Week's guide to what's worth watching**The Bluff**

Nothing beats the winter doldrums like a swash-buckling island adventure. Priyanka Chopra Jonas headlines this hook-and-eyepatch feature as a former pirate, once known as Bloody Mary, who quit treasure-looting to live a quiet family life in the Cayman Islands. Her ex-captain, played by Karl Urban, has other ideas. He's pursuing vengeance when he and his men hunt her down, only to discover that her deadly fighting skills haven't faded. *Wednesday, Feb. 25, Prime*

The Gray House

During the Civil War, a group of women in Richmond, Va., risked their lives to turn a branch of the Underground Railroad into a spy network that helped end slavery. In this eight-part series produced by Morgan Freeman and Kevin Costner, Daisy Head plays a socialite who, with her mother's help, leads a clandestine operation that reaches into hospitals, brothels, and, through an enslaved ally, Jefferson Davis' mansion. Mary-Louise Parker, Hannah James, and Amethyst Davis co-star. *Thursday, Feb. 26, Prime*

Paul McCartney: Man on the Run

What to do after seven years in the world's biggest rock band? In this documentary from *20 Feet From Stardom* director Morgan Neville, 29-year-old Paul McCartney puts aside thoughts of quitting music to launch Wings, bringing aboard his wife, Linda; former Moody Blues guitarist Denny Laine; and a handful of other collaborators. McCartney and friends tell the story of the band, which powered through the 1970s with hits ranging from "Jet" to "Silly Love Songs." *Friday, Feb. 27, Prime*

Marshals

It's a new day for one member of the Dutton family. In this spin-off of *Yellowstone*, the hit Taylor Sheridan series, Luke Grimes reprises his role as Kayce Dutton, who is looking for purpose following his decision to sell the family's Montana ranch to the Broken Rock tribe. Drawing on his experience as a Navy SEAL, Kayce



'Gray House' co-conspirators Davis, Parker, and Head

joins a team of federal marshals battling criminal gangs wreaking havoc across the region. *Sunday, March 1, at 8 p.m., CBS*

American Classic

It's on with the show for a fallen Broadway celebrity in this new comedy series starring Kevin Kline, Laura Linney, and Tony Shalhoub. Kline plays a high-profile self-centered actor who has just publicly disgraced himself when the death of his mother requires a return to his hometown. He creates plenty of trouble before devoting himself to a local production of *Our Town*. *Sunday, March 1, at 9 p.m., MGM+*

Other highlights
Scrubs

A reboot of the long-running hospital-comedy series reunites Zach Braff, Donald Faison, Sarah Chalke, and other original cast members. *Wednesday, Feb. 25, at 8 p.m., ABC*

Monarch: Legacy of Monsters

In Season 2 of this superb creature-feature series, the monster-monitoring organization Monarch seeks to recruit Godzilla and King Kong to battle the tentacled Titan X. *Friday, Feb. 27, Apple TV*

The 2026 Actor Awards

The stars gather again for the pre-Oscars event formerly known as the Screen Actors Guild Awards. *Sunday, March 1, at 8 p.m., Netflix*

Show of the week**DTF St. Louis**

Affairs, hookups, a suspicious death—suburban St. Louis has it all in this racy, delightfully dark new comedy-mystery series. Jason Bateman and David Harbour co-star as friendly colleagues at a local news station who take different paths to sexual adventure. Prompted by his pal, Harbour's Floyd becomes obsessed with a hookup app called DTF St. Louis. Bateman's Clark, meanwhile, begins an affair with Floyd's wife, who's played by Linda Cardellini. When Floyd is found dead, Richard Jenkins and Joy Sunday join the drama as investigators digging for answers. *Sunday, March 1, at 9 p.m., HBO and HBO Max*



Bateman and Harbour: Such normal guys, right?

A borsch from Odesa: When delicious alone isn't enough

In Ukraine's third-largest city, home cooks take great pride in the color of their borsch, said Maria Kalenska in *Cuisines of Odesa* (Weldon Owen). The use of chicken distinguishes this recipe as a Jewish version of the Ukrainian beet soup, which is normally made with beef, duck, or no meat. Several steps here, such as adding beets late in the cooking process, help retain the soup's vibrant red color.

Recipe of the week A very bright chicken borsch

- 1 whole chicken, about 2¾ lb
(preferably corn-fed and organic)
- 2 beets
- 2 potatoes
- ½ cabbage
- ¼ celery root
- 1 parsley root
- 2 carrots
- 1 large onion
- About 6 tbsp sunflower oil
- 4 tomatoes or 2 tbsp tomato paste
- 9 oz canned butter beans, drained
- A handful of fresh flat-leaf parsley, roughly chopped
- A handful of fresh dill, roughly chopped
- Sea salt
- 1 tbsp superfine (caster) sugar
- Sourdough rye bread, sour cream, and garlic cloves, for serving

Place chicken in a 5¼-qt pot, cover with cold water, and bring to a boil over



Beets in all their glory

medium-high heat. Skim off any foam, reduce heat to low, and cover with a lid. Simmer for at least 30 minutes, or until chicken is tender. Transfer chicken from broth to a large bowl, let it cool, and separate meat from the bones. Chop meat into small pieces. Keep broth warm over very low heat.

Meanwhile, carefully scrub beets to remove any dirt. Place in a small saucepan, cover with water, and bring to a boil over high heat. Reduce heat and simmer for 20 minutes. Let beets cool, then peel. Dice one beet and grate the other; this will give soup

a variety of textures and enhance its color.

Cut potatoes into cubes. Shred cabbage into thin strips. Place potatoes and cabbage in a medium saucepan, add a small amount of water, and bring to a boil over high heat. Cover with a lid, reduce heat, and simmer for about 15 minutes. Remove from heat and reserve cooking liquid.

Peel and dice celery root, parsley root, carrots, and onion. Heat sunflower oil in a large frying pan over medium heat. Add celery root, parsley root, and carrots; sauté until softened. Add onion, and sauté until onion is golden. Remove pan from heat.

Cut tomatoes in half and grate them into a bowl.

Return broth to a boil. Add cooked potatoes and cabbage along with about 2½ cups of their cooking liquid. Add butter beans, chicken, sautéed celery root mixture, and diced and grated beets. Simmer for 10 minutes.

Add grated tomatoes or tomato paste to soup. The tomatoes' acidity helps the beets retain their color. Bring to a boil and simmer for 5 minutes, then add parsley and dill. Season with salt and sugar to balance the acidity. Let soup simmer for 5 minutes more, then reduce heat and simmer gently for 3 minutes.

Ladle borsch into bowls, spoon sour cream on top, and bring to table with rye bread (and garlic cloves, for nibbling between spoonfuls). Serves 8 to 10.

Dining out: The best of Burlington, Vt.

Set on Lake Champlain beside the Green Mountains, Burlington is a Vermont postcard come to life, said Tanner Bowden in *The Infatuation*. "Look beyond the Bernie Sanders and Ben & Jerry's of it all" and you'll soon see that this city of roughly 45,000 is "defined by practicality, community, and a tradition of artisanship." At Burlington's restaurants, "farm-to-table isn't an angle, it's just how things work."

Fancy's "Drop Fancy's into a dimmer, tableclothed room and it'd pass for fine dining, but here it's just an awesome neighborhood spot." The shareable, mostly vegetarian plates are "truly unique," from crispy rice-and-lentil pancakes to Brussels sprouts in gochujang cashew queso. 88 Oak St.

Hen of the Wood Picture patrons in sweaters, freshly split wood on a crackling fire, and mezcal cocktails among the bar options. "The Vermont-iness is also reflected on the menu," in a list of local cheeses and a dedication to highlighting local produce. What's more, "the Hen is a great place to get a steak." 55 Cherry St.

May Day This is one of those restaurants that "doesn't take itself too seriously but



Haute cozy at Hen of the Wood

clearly knows what it's doing." Cocktails like the spaghetti (a Miller High Life with Aperol) set the tone, and "the food is fun, too." The house specialties are "comfort classics prepared with a little extra panache," such as chicken schnitzel with peperonata and steak frites with Bayley Hazen

blue cheese. 258 N. Winooski Ave.
Philo Ridge Farm Farm and restaurant are "one and the same" at Philo Ridge, where the food is sourced from 500 surrounding acres. Make the drive south from town for surprises such as roasted beets with a spicy raspberry sauce and arugula and bread dumplings with pickled pear. 2766 Mount Philo Rd.

Pinot blanc: A winter white

Pinot blanc "has a reputation for being bland," said Alissa Bica Raines in *Food & Wine*. But the grape, when handled right, yields "complex, texturally interesting wines that pair beautifully with a wide range of dishes." Pinot blanc is also "an ideal winter white" because it's crisp, mineral-forward, and most expressive when served at room temperature.

2025 Alois Lageder Terra Alpina Pinot Bianco (\$20). A great value, this pinot bianco from Italy's Dolomites "leads with salty almond skin, followed by crisp green apple and apricot fruit."

2023 Domaine Weinbach Pinot Blanc Réserve (\$35).

"Elegant white florals and caramelized peach" headline this wine, "a great example of how structured pinot blanc can be."

2023 Alma Rosa Sta. Rita Hills Pinot Blanc (\$35). "A perfect hybrid of New World ripeness and Old World minerality," this pinot blanc delivers "racy" acidity plus a lemon citrus finish.



This week's dream: An ocean crossing on the *Queen Mary 2*

The *Queen Mary 2* “promises to be exceptional,” and indeed it is, said Christine Mi in *The Washington Post*. Three times heavier than the *Titanic*, the 23-year-old vessel is the largest ocean liner ever built, and when I boarded it in Brooklyn last year after booking a solo cabin, I was enthralled by the idea that crossing the Atlantic by such a time-honored means would enable me to experience “the true immensity of the act.” In the end, I wasn’t entirely wrong. But I’m no fan of cruises, and “the main difference between the *QM2* and a regular cruise was that there was no getting off the ship.” Predictably, over the next seven days, “I slowly lost my mind.”

It’s not that the *QM2* lacked activities. Scheduled entertainment, from movie screenings to line dancing, was available 16 hours a day. But even though I teamed up with older strangers to participate in trivia events about three times a day, and even though those older strangers were almost invariably nice, I was soon suffering



The ship’s 1,000-seat prime restaurant

“the peculiar kind of dull, aching restlessness that accompanies a life stripped of all friction and responsibility.” The ship’s 15 restaurants, three pools, casino, and dressy themed dinners couldn’t cure that. In fact, the fantasy world built for us

deeply troubled me. “There was something so specious about a ship full of moneyed white Brits and Americans reenacting the golden days of the 1920s, eating steak and lobster while being waited on by an army of attendants from the Global South.”

While most of my fellow passengers preferred blinding themselves to the journey’s existential dimensions, I soaked them up. At day’s end, I stared out at the ocean from the deck or my cabin’s enclosed balcony. One evening, “I witnessed the most devastating sunset of my life.” On another, I watched lightning bore into the sea as a storm engulfed us. I felt fully in touch with how small we are and how short our lives in the context of the ancient Atlantic. By the time we neared port in Southampton, U.K., I’d even reconsidered my initial impression. “Maybe it wasn’t that bad to lose your mind in the middle of the ocean.” *Eastbound seven-day Atlantic crossings aboard Cunard’s Queen Mary 2 (cunard.com) start at \$2,438 for two.*

Hotel of the week



Like a club without member fees

L’Aventure Hotel Paris

One of Paris’ most in-demand nightspots has begun welcoming overnight guests, said Tina Isaac-Goizé in *The New York Times*. L’Aventure, a year-old nightclub and restaurant that revived a storied 1980s nocturnal destination, is a creation of the Costes family, whose “particular brand of velvet-rope hospitality” has established their multiple properties as Fashion Week favorites. The family’s new auberge, occupying the upper floors of an 1870 corner building across from the Arc de Triomphe, has just 15 rooms, including a penthouse. It’s “decorated in the spirit of a whimsical private townhouse.” It also has a butler always on call. *laventurehotel.com; doubles from \$641*

Getting the flavor of...

Spending \$1,000 in Charleston

“For history, scenery, and culinary fireworks all packed into a tiny footprint, few U.S. cities can compete with Charleston, S.C.,” said Matthew Kronsberg in *The Wall Street Journal*. With a budget of just \$1,000 for a three-day stay, you can soak in many of its pleasures, as I learned recently. And that was including \$258 for a rental car and \$274 for two nights at the renovated Starlight Motor Inn south of town. After a hearty lunch at King BBQ that featured three lacquered beef ribs, I headed straight to King Street and wandered among its stores before enjoying an African-inspired crab stir-fry that night at Bintü Atelier, a short drive away. The next day, I strolled White Point Garden, at the tip of the city’s peninsula, before a stirring visit to the International African American Museum, lunch, and a tour of an 1820 mansion. Having packed my days with good meals and coffee and cocktail breaks, I stretched my last \$100 on Day 3 by driving 25 minutes for a hike to the beach at Sullivan’s Island. The car proved a smart investment.

Living like the Cree in upper Quebec

Icy air filled our lungs as we snowshoed alongside Lake Waconichi, said Abi Hayward in *Canadian Geographic*. We were in northern Quebec, in a national park founded just a year ago, and our Cree guide, Clifford Neeposh, was showing us the clearing where he lived while growing up and the remains of a winter shelter like those his grandfather used to

build. Nibiischii National Park is now managed by the Cree Nation of Mistissini, making the Cree community our hosts at Waconichi Lodge, which has 11 cabins linked by boardwalks and two more set atop the lake’s ice. “It’s a cozy place to stay on the edge of the boreal forest,” with locally prepared meals ordered in and plenty of chances to become immersed in Cree culture. The lodge’s “beating heart” is a traditional Cree shelter where Mario Lord, the tribe’s cultural director, showed us how to weave tamarack branches into goose decoys, how to build a fire, how to cook a goose, and much more. “The best way to learn it,” Lord says, “is to live it.”

Joining the ‘microvacation’ craze

When the daily grind has you down, “sometimes a small break is enough to lift your mood,” said Choncé Maddox in *Kiplinger*. “Microvacations” are trending among U.S. travelers, with one survey indicating that nearly 75% expect to make at least one getaway of four nights or less each year. That makes sense, because short escapes are more affordable and easier to schedule, and the mental health benefits are real. “The point isn’t how far you go,” so consider even an overnight stay somewhere within driving distance. “One of the best parts of microvacations is how flexible they are. You can shape them around what you need right now: rest, connection, fun, or simply a change of scenery.” While planning activities, “pick one or two things you really want to do, then leave room for rest.”

Women around the world are demanding access to safe, modern reproductive healthcare.

One in ten women cannot make decisions for themselves about the use of contraception and 257 million women worldwide can't access contraception at all.

MSI Reproductive Choices is committed to accelerating progress toward universal access to contraception.

We're calling on funders, philanthropists and everyone who cares about reproductive choice, freedom and opportunity to join us in this commitment.

Global access to contraception is an achievable goal.



msiunitedstates.org



Best Properties on the Market

This week: Homes with fun rooms for kids



Klaudia McBride/Reel & Shutter—Bay Area



1 ◀ Los Gatos, Calif. Built in 1924, this six-bedroom updated Craftsman in a town outside San Jose has two kids' rooms, one with a uniquely angled roofline, wall-to-wall carpeting, and a play area. A sitting and dining room clad in botanical wallpaper has a fireplace and connects to a kitchen with a bay window. The corner lot includes a pool, a pergola-topped patio, paths, and two unfinished yards with recreational potential. \$5,875,000. Kirsten Trapani and Bart Call, Christie's International Real Estate Sereno, (408) 761-0686



2 ▶ Sarasota, Fla. A floor-to-ceiling wood tree sculpture supporting a loft anchors the modern kids' room in this 1952 ranch home in the Avondale neighborhood. Expanded in 2022, the five-bedroom has shiplap ceilings and wood floors, a butler's pantry, a gym, and a terrazzo-floored playroom that opens to a pool beside a play structure. Downtown is walking distance, and an elementary school is a short drive. \$3,495,000. Jennifer Linehan, Michael Saunders & Company/Luxury Portfolio International, (941) 266-7555



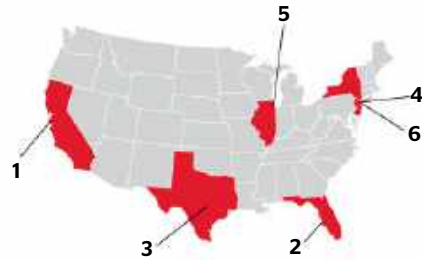
3 ◀ West Lake Hills, Texas In an Austin suburb, this 2024 organic modern home features several children's rooms, including one with floor-to-ceiling windows overlooking treetops, and one that's a nursery with a large-scale peony mural. The five-bedroom's foyer has walnut-clad walls and a floating staircase,

and the living room features a 27-foot retractable glass wall, clerestory windows, and a view of the pool. The lot has yards, mature trees, and landscaping. The city is about a 20-minute drive. \$6,000,000. Laurel Prats, Compass, (512) 636-7579

Best Properties on the Market



4 ◀ Brooklyn
This three-bedroom condo in a Williamsburg loft building built in 1910 offers two potential kids' bedrooms with tall ceilings, exposed rough-hewn beams, and oversize windows. The open kitchen has Shaker cabinets, a Wolf stove, and a Sub-Zero fridge, while original restored wood floors run throughout the home. Outdoor space includes two private balconies, a roof deck, and a shared roof playground; shops on Bedford Avenue are a short walk away. \$5,495,000. Warner Lewis, Brown Harris Stevens, (212) 381-6590



5 ▶ Chicago The 1913 Lincoln Street Bath House, once a municipal washing place when indoor plumbing was rare, is now a six-bedroom modernist home with a children's room featuring an elevated platform storage bed and a play loft. The 10,000-square-foot East Village dwelling has high ceilings, concrete floors, a kitchen with a double-sided fireplace, a sunken soaker tub, colorful tiles, and vibrant wallpapers. Outside are a sports court, patio, and kitchen. \$5,750,000. Jennifer Mills, Jameson Sotheby's International Realty, (773) 914-4422



Robert Englebright/Englebright Photography

Steal of the week



6 ◀ East Orange, N.J.
Near parks and schools, this refreshed 1940 Colonial four-bedroom has a second-floor children's room with tree views, hardwood floors, and access to a bright bathroom with its original aqua tub and sink. On the main floor are a wood-burning fireplace, a formal dining room, and an eat-in kitchen; a finished basement has a wood-paneled playroom. The yard is fenced, and New York City is about an hour by train. \$459,000. Vikram Vasisht, Prominent Properties Sotheby's International Realty, (917) 685-2606

The News at a Glance

The bottom line

■ The median American worker has only \$955 saved for retirement through a defined contribution plan such as a 401(k) account, with most employees falling well short of recommended retirement-savings targets for their ages, according to the National Institute on Retirement Security.

FoxBusiness.com

■ More middle-class Americans are selling their plasma to make ends meet. Donation centers are popping up in suburban strip malls and college towns. Last year, Americans sold 30% more plasma than they did in 2022, supplementing their income by an estimated \$4.7 billion.

NBCNews.com

■ Horse racing is experiencing a renaissance, thanks largely to a change tucked into President Trump's 2025 tax law that makes it easier for owners to write off the cost of racehorses. The Keeneland September Yearling Sale in Lexington, Ky., one of the world's



premier horse auctions, set a global record in 2025 with \$531.5 million in sales, up nearly 24% from the year before.

The New York Times

■ Bayer AG has agreed to pay more than \$7 billion as part of a push to resolve current and future cancer lawsuits over its top-selling Roundup weed killer, in a settlement plan intended to end litigation that has ensnared the company for years.

Bloomberg

■ Lenders to commercial real estate firms are calling in tens of billions of dollars of troubled loans as refinancing becomes increasingly difficult for property owners. The delinquency rate for office loans in commercial mortgage-backed securities climbed to a record 12.34% in January.

The Wall Street Journal

Leadership: CEOs replaced in record numbers

We haven't seen this big a crop of new leaders running corporate America since the depths of the financial crisis in 2010, said Theo Francis in *The Wall Street Journal*. About 1 in 9 CEOs across the top 1,500 largest public companies were replaced last year as companies sought a fresh batch of leaders to tackle challenges such as AI and President Trump's



Walmart's new boss, John Furman

"unraveling of long-established trade practices." The newcomers are younger and less seasoned than the bosses they replaced. More than 80% of last year's 168 new CEOs were first timers with "no prior experience running public companies or other major stand-alone enterprises." Two-thirds had never served on a board before. The pace "doesn't appear to be slowing." Dozens of firms

brought in new CEOs in the first two months of 2026, including Walmart and Procter & Gamble.

Welcome to "the age of the disposable leader," said Pilita Clark in the *Financial Times*. Given "the mushrooming uncertainties of modern business life," it's understandable that boards and shareholders are tempted to seek new CEOs who aren't afraid to

"move fast and break things." But a rapid turnover in top jobs bears its own perils. Hiring a boss who could potentially be gone tomorrow is "a recipe for morale-sapping discontent, not least for managers trying to figure out strategic priorities." Sometimes you need someone to shake things up, but "those who go slower and fix things can end up doing even more."

Media: Paramount ups its Warner Bros. bid

Warner Bros. Discovery is "trying to ensure it squeezes every possible billion out of its suitors," said Brian Stelter in *CNN.com*. While still moving forward with Netflix's \$82.7 billion takeover deal, which Warner's board has approved, the studio giant this week asked hostile bidder Paramount to come up with its "best and final proposal." Paramount has already sweetened its initial \$30-a-share bid, but Warner CEO David Zaslav said it now gets another chance to address the "deficiencies" in its offer. Whatever Paramount's answer, Warner's board is confident "Netflix can and likely will match the price."

Defense: Pentagon and Anthropic clash over AI use

The Defense Department this week threatened to cut business ties with Anthropic and label the AI firm a "supply chain risk," said Dave Lawler in *Axios*. Such a designation would require anyone who does business with the Pentagon to certify that they do not use Anthropic's technology. At the heart of the clash is a dispute over the terms under which the military can use Anthropic's Claude chatbot, which was deployed in the recent operation to capture Venezuelan president Nicolás Maduro. Anthropic "wants to ensure its tools aren't used to spy on Americans en masse or to develop weapons that fire with no human involvement." A Pentagon spokesperson said that's too restrictive, and that all contractors must "be willing to help our warfighters win in any fight."

Goldman Sachs: Dumping DEI

One of the nation's largest financial institutions is retreating further on DEI commitments, said AnnaMaria Andriotis in *The Wall Street Journal*. Goldman Sachs this week announced it will no longer consider factors such as race, gender, or sexual orientation when selecting new directors for its board. The bank last year "retooled" a program to invest in Black businesswomen and scrapped a requirement that companies have diverse boards for Goldman to take them public. The latest action follows a "behind-the-scenes request" from a conservative nonprofit activist group with a small stake in the company.

Surveillance: Ring ends neighborhood watch feature

Ring is terminating its new "Search Party" feature, said Mark Walker in *The New York Times*. The Amazon-owned company has faced a severe backlash since it promoted the technology in a Super Bowl commercial this month. The ad showed home security cameras connecting to locate a lost dog; critics said it "felt more invasive than heartwarming" and that Ring could also be used "to track people's everyday movements."

The grocery store is the place to be seen

At a time when people are desperate for connection, some top-line grocery stores are casting themselves as "an entry point" to an exclusive community, said *The New York Times*. Happier Grocery in the SoHo neighborhood of New York City, for instance, doesn't just sell \$14 mango smoothies and \$16 turmeric-ginger chocolate bars. Its customers can also work in its office space and attend "chess nights, family-style dinner parties with chefs, yoga and breath work classes, or knitting workshops led by Ella Emhoff," step-daughter of former vice president Kamala Harris. A separate members-only club and a hotel are in development. Happier Grocery, which has a podcast, branded apparel, and a YouTube channel, is focused on "taking a run-of-the-mill business and turning it into a lifestyle brand." Dozens of similar stores across the country no longer "depend on their goods to turn a profit," but figure instead that "once enough people are collected, the business opportunities are endless."

Making Money

AI: When your financial adviser is a chatbot

More people are turning to AI chatbots for tax help, investment advice, and even retirement planning, said **Kailyn Rhone** in *The New York Times*. Nearly one-third of people who have used artificial intelligence for financial advice have asked about retirement, according to a survey from Intuit Credit Karma. The draw is understandable. Artificial intelligence tools “are easy to access, respond instantly, and often don’t charge fees.” Users can also ask a chatbot “questions they may be embarrassed to ask a human adviser.” Caitlyn Yingling, a recruiter in Dallas, looked at her 401(k) for the first time ever last September and realized her investments were in a target-date fund for someone who would have retired in 2015. She turned to ChatGPT, which “urged her to reallocate her investments using a more aggressive strategy”—appropriate advice for someone in her early 30s. She also reviewed those changes with a human financial adviser.

I wouldn’t completely trust a bot with my money, said **Peter Coy** in *The Wall Street Journal*. “They’re sociopaths—smooth, persuasive, and devoid of empathy.” One day, maybe, AI could become “a true fiduciary.” But it would need not only to understand laws, regulations, and court cases; it must also acquire the “digital equivalents of empathy, humility, and a sense of fairness.” For now, bots have biases, make mistakes, and “don’t have the



Would you let AI guide your 401(k)?

relationship-based part of the job has never been more crucial.” That’s not to say ChatGPT can’t have some good ideas for your portfolio, said **Lucy Lazarony** in *Investopedia*, and it might even be a helpful resource for retirement planning. But if you are going to get advice from a bot, do so cautiously. ChatGPT and Google’s Gemini are best at answering factual questions about general concepts, such as deciding when to collect Social Security benefits, “estimating medical costs, and choosing which retirement accounts to tap first to minimize taxes.” Always review the sources cited by the chatbot to ensure the information it provides isn’t outdated, and be careful about what private data you give the AI. “The information you enter is often used as training data and could be subject to hacking and data breaches.”

training to act in users’ best interest.” You’d think credit investing would be “a natural area for large language models to be deployed,” said **Sujeet Indap** in the *Financial Times*. “Investing in loans and bonds requires as much number crunching as the review of legal contracts and knowledge of the law.” But investors on Wall Street remain hesitant to turn it all over to machines. There is still value to “human service” and the ability to “pick up the phone and bounce trading ideas off a human expert.” In some ways, AI has shown Wall Street that the “real-life,

What the experts say

■ Higher SALT cap lifts tax refunds

Homeowners in several blue states “will be among the biggest winners this filing season,” said Caitlin Reilly in *Bloomberg*. Thanks to a provision in last year’s GOP-authored tax bill that raised the cap on state and local taxes (SALT) from \$10,000 to \$40,000, “many New York, New Jersey, and California residents are enjoying supercharged tax savings.” According to analysis by the Bipartisan Policy Center, “a couple maximizing the deduction could see up to \$9,600 cut from their taxes this filing season.” All told, the expanded SALT cap is expected to deliver \$32 billion in savings this year. But not everyone is able to claim it: Those earning between \$500,000 and \$600,000 “will see their deduction phase out,” while those earning above \$600,000 can still “only claim \$10,000 in SALT write-offs.”

■ Cheaper alternatives to TrumpRx

President Trump promised his new consumer drug-pricing site would offer “the world’s lowest prices on prescription drugs,” said Maya Goldman in *Axios*. But of the 43 brand name drugs on TrumpRx.gov, “20 have generic versions that can be purchased at other pharmacies or direct-to-consumer websites.” For instance, an antidepressant listed on TrumpRx

for \$200 a month (with a 50% off coupon) is available in a generic version for under \$30 on GoodRx and \$16.65 on Mark Cuban’s CostPlusDrugs. A White House spokesperson said TrumpRx’s “value is in providing the lowest-cost option for branded products” from drug companies including Pfizer, Astra Zeneca, and Eli Lilly. But in many cases, “patients could save more by buying nonbrand cypoccat drugs, even if they don’t have insurance.”

■ Google issues rare 100-year bond

Investors are betting Google’s parent company, Alphabet, will be around for a long, long time, said Allison Morrow in *CNN.com*. The tech giant last week issued “an extremely rare corporate bond” that matures a century from now—the year 2126, to be exact. Still, investors leaped at the offer, buying more than \$1.37 billion worth of coupons, which yield over 6%. That’s a fat return at a time when interest rates have been heading lower. Century bonds are rare but not unheard of, “and it hasn’t always worked out great for those that have done it.” JC Penney raised \$500 million through 100-year bonds in 1997, but they didn’t even survive a quarter century—the retailer went bankrupt in 2020. The last U.S. company to issue this kind of debt was Motorola in 1997.

Charity of the week



Most feral cats are considered unadoptable if they make it to a shelter, and they tend to end up euthanized. The nonprofit organization **Neighborhood Cats** (neighborhoodcats.org), founded in New York City in 1999, pioneered methods used around the world today to neuter and vaccinate feral cat populations and has helped spare the lives of thousands of street cats. The group designed the first commercially available drop trap, and it helps beginner trappers pair up with experienced mentors to start catching and treating feral animals in their communities. In the winter, it distributes insulated cat shelters to volunteers in low-income areas. The nonprofit now has offices in New York City, New Jersey, and Maui, where it helped rescue more than 600 cats during the 2023 Lahaina wildfire. Neighborhood Cats also provides advice and assistance to similar programs in Indonesia, Kenya, and Australia.

Each charity we feature has earned a four-star overall rating from Charity Navigator, which rates not-for-profit organizations on the strength of their finances, their governance practices, and the transparency of their operations. Four stars is the group’s highest rating.

Employment: A jobs report filled with mixed signals

The Bureau of Labor Statistics released a “Schrödinger’s cat of employment snapshots” last week, said Alicia Wallace in *CNN.com*. It reported that the U.S. added 130,000 jobs in January, far more than economists forecast, suggesting a stabilizing employment market after months of deteriorating numbers. But the bureau also revised down its jobs numbers for last year to show 2025 to be “one of the worst years ever for job creation outside of a recession.” The annual recalibration meant that “a million U.S. jobs disappeared overnight,” said Larry Edelman in *The Boston Globe*. “Poof!” In fact, those roles didn’t vanish—they “never existed in the first place.” The revisions don’t mean the department is incompetent or “plays politics with the numbers to make a president look good or bad.” They just reflect updates as more data emerges. The main takeaway is that last year, “the economy added an average of 15,000 jobs a month, even fewer than the paltry 49,000 average previously estimated.”



A jobs fair in Seattle

The January report had one bright spot, said Vince Golle in *Bloomberg*. Factory jobs increased for the first time since late 2024, a sign that “American manufacturing may be starting to emerge from years of malaise.” Combine those gains “with a solid advance in the construction industry”—powered in part by data center build-outs—and we see a gain of 36,000 jobs “among goods producers, the most since mid-2023.” Still, the “lion’s share” of job growth came “from one specific task: caring for older Americans,” said Allie Canal in *NBCNews.com*. About 124,000 of last month’s 130,000 new jobs were in the

health-care sector. We’re not talking about a boom in highly skilled and well-paid surgeons, but rather more home health and personal care aides. “Demand for long-term care is projected to keep rising” as the U.S. population ages. Most of the direct care workforce performs physically demanding work for a median wage of \$16.82 an hour, barely enough to exceed the \$32,150 federal poverty level for a family of four. And as immigration restrictions tighten, “the strain on this workforce is building at the very moment the country needs it most.”

The White House wants Americans to believe “that near-zero job growth is fine because immigration has plunged,” said Paul Krugman in his *Substack* newsletter. “All of the jobs that we were creating in the Biden years were going to illegals,” senior trade adviser Peter Navarro said last week. “Americans were going to the unemployment lines.” But the evidence shows that immigrants are “mainly complements, not substitutes, for native-born workers,” filling jobs others don’t want in agriculture, meatpacking, construction, and, yes, health care. Close to 40% of home health aides and 28% of personal care aides are immigrants, according to data from the Migration Policy Institute. One recent academic paper found that “the arrival of an extra 1,000 immigrants leads to employment of an additional 28 aides, 49 nurses, and 19 doctors.” And like the vast majority of immigrants, those workers pay taxes and boost economic growth. Waging war on them will “make native-born Americans poorer—and send thousands of us to an early grave.”

How to build a housing bubble

Allysia Finley
The Wall Street Journal

A “wrong-headed political drive” to make housing more affordable could fuel a repeat of the 2008 financial crisis, said Allysia Finley. During the Biden administration, homebuyers seeking a mortgage were required to submit credit scores from both FICO and VantageScore, which apply different formulas to inputs from the three main credit bureaus. But last summer, Federal Housing Finance Agency Director Bill Pulte announced that “lenders would be allowed to choose which score to use when underwriting mortgages.” Such “score shopping” lets lenders increase approvals and expand access to housing credit. It also incentivizes FICO and VantageScore

to artificially inflate their scores to boost their own business, leading to more defaults on unsustainable loans and a bigger burden on Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac, the government-sponsored enterprises that set housing lending standards. Risk advisers say if FICO and VantageScore start tweaking their models to inflate credit scores, severe delinquency rates could increase by 18% or more. Does this all sound familiar? It should for anyone around during the housing bubble of the 2000s, when foreclosures soared and the market crashed. Then as now, “perverse incentives” allow lenders and credit firms to “foist the costs onto taxpayers.”

A gold rush for GLP-1 knockoffs

Lisa Jarvis
Bloomberg

The alternative GLP-1 market is “the Wild West” of the pharmaceutical industry, said Lisa Jarvis. When a medication is in short supply, regulators allow “compounded” alternatives: customized mixtures of popular drugs that differ slightly from the original and aren’t subject to the same FDA oversight. So when demand overwhelmed supply of popular weight-loss medications such as Ozempic, “a gray market took off, with telehealth companies, online pharmacies, and wellness spas offering knock-off versions.” From lozenges to under-the-tongue drops, the public has been “bombarded with ads for cheap, easily accessible alternatives” to drugs

that underwent the arduous FDA approval process. There’s no guarantee that these alternatives are safe or effective, and the FDA has recently stepped up efforts to curb their sale. Telehealth firm Hims & Hers yanked a compounded version of a Wegovy pill from the market this month after regulators threatened to take action if it didn’t. Given the size of the gray market, though, “it’s hard to imagine it’ll be easy to shut it all down.” Competition is bringing down prices for approved GLP-1 drugs, but “insurance coverage remains spotty at best,” leaving them out of reach for millions—and assuring an ongoing market for “whatever is cheapest.”

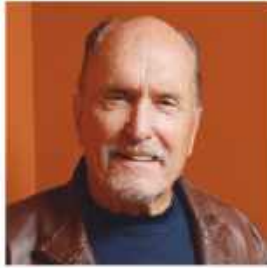
Obituaries

The shape-shifter who could be savage or sweet

Robert Duvall
1931-2026

Robert Duvall disappeared into his characters. Over a six-decade career he approached highly diverse roles like “an ethnologist on a field trip into the soul,” as one critic put it. Among his memorable leading performances were roles as an explosive Marine pilot who tyrannizes his family in *The Great Santini* (1979) and as a fading, alcoholic country singer in *Tender Mercies* (1983), which won him a Best Actor Oscar. He also starred as an illiterate, deeply kind farmer in the Faulkner adaptation *Tomorrow* (1972), and as a fallen Pentecostal preacher in *The Apostle* (1997), which he wrote and directed. But many of Duvall’s best performances came in supporting roles: as a ruthless TV executive in *Network* (1976), the stoic mob lawyer in *The Godfather* (1972), and the maniacal lieutenant colonel in *Apocalypse Now* (1979) who loves “the smell of napalm in the morning.” Secondary roles suited Duvall just fine, he said, and were often more interesting. “Being a leading man is an agent’s dream,” he said, “not an actor’s.”

Born in San Diego, Duvall grew up in a series of Navy towns where his rear admiral father was stationed, said the Associated Press. An aimless youth, he attended Principia College in Illinois



but “nearly flunked out.” His concerned parents steered him toward theater and he “flourished in drama classes.” After his Army service, he moved to New York City to study acting, falling in with fellow students Gene Hackman and Dustin Hoffman. Working odd jobs to support himself, he soon began landing stage and TV roles. He “got his film break” when cast as the misunderstood recluse Boo Radley in *To Kill a Mockingbird* (1962), said *Rolling Stone*, making an indelible impression without speaking a word of dialogue. Having built his reputation as a character actor over the next decade, he became “a central figure in the New Hollywood of the 1970s,” adding “grit and soul to legendary works” from directors such as George Lucas, Robert Altman, and Francis Ford Coppola.

An exacting performer who researched roles with “intense studiousness,” Duvall was also a private man who kept “Hollywood at arm’s length,” said *The New York Times*. He spent years living with his fourth wife on a horse farm in rural Virginia, though he acted into his 90s. Despite that intensity, he was unpretentious about his craft, which, he said, just boiled down to “talking and listening.” In acting, “there’s no right or wrong,” he said, “just truthful or untruthful.”

The *Harold and Maude* star who never quite made it big

Bud Cort’s one breakout role made him an eternal symbol of the misfit. The actor was 21 when he was cast in the 1971 black comedy *Harold and Maude* opposite Ruth Gordon, who was 75. He played a wealthy teen obsessed with death who happens into a life-affirming romantic relationship with Gordon’s

Bud Cort
1948-2026

eccentric Holocaust survivor. While the film bombed initially,

it gained a devoted cult following. “People used to come to my hotel and leave tombstones and pictures of dead babies,” Cort said in 2000. “They missed the point of the movie.”

Born Walter Edward Cox in Rye, N.Y., Cort had a cold and distant father who led a big band, said *The Telegraph* (U.K.). But he met many celebrities through his mother’s job as a studio publicist, and he would “fantasize that Clark Gable was his real father.” He first set out to be a painter, but once he turned to acting, he changed his name to avoid confusion with comedian Wally Cox. At 20 he got a small role in *M*A*S*H* (1970), and its director, Robert Altman, “became his mentor,” giving him the title role in *Brewster McCLOUD* (1970) and recommending him for *Harold and Maude*.

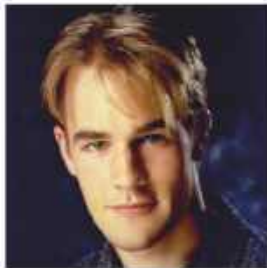
After that star turn, though, Cort became “something of an outcast” in Hollywood, said *The New York Times*. He bickered with directors and lost at least one plum supporting role because “he insisted that he get the lead.” A serious car accident that necessitated extensive facial reconstruction further set back his career, and he spent a decade living as the house guest of an elderly Groucho Marx. Yet he never stopped auditioning, appearing in over 40 movies and dozens of TV shows. When he gave up his childhood dream of painting, he said, “with time I realized that every part I played could actually be its own portrait.”

The heartthrob who was loved by a generation

James Van Der Beek
1977-2026

James Van Der Beek set the mold for sensitive young men. From the moment he appeared onscreen in 1998 as 15-year-old Dawson Leery in *Dawson’s Creek*, he touched viewers with his portrayal of a precocious guy with a wide-open heart. Millennial teens fell in love with the floppy-haired blond over six seasons of the WB drama, hooked by a show that talked frankly about sexuality while also showing the childlike vulnerability of high schoolers. A clip of Van Der Beek ugly-crying as he breaks up with his first love, played by Katie Holmes, remains a popular meme. As Van Der Beek’s fame grew, he starred in the coming-of-age film *Varsity Blues* (1999) and as a selfish nihilist in *The Rules of Attraction* (2002). He said he happily gave his whole self to his roles. I just “go in and be completely open and just jump in with both feet,” he said in 2013. “Everything you do belongs to the audience, ultimately.”

Van Der Beek grew up acting in school plays in Connecticut and at 15 begged his mother to help him find an agent. He was soon drawing admiring reviews off-Broadway, and he dropped out of New Jersey’s Drew University when he landed



Dawson’s Creek. The show’s creator thought Van Der Beek’s visible nervousness in the audition made him a natural fit for the sensitive Dawson. But “it was never his intention to get so famous,” said *Rolling Stone*, and he found the adulation exhausting and dehumanizing. Within weeks of the premiere, he needed a police escort to escape fawning mobs of teenage girls.

Van Der Beek “struggled to transition into adult roles” after *Dawson’s Creek*, said *The Washington Post*, and “he revived his career partly by poking fun at himself.” In several later roles, he played an obnoxious, egotistical version of a Dawson type. He was not “limited by genre,” said *Vogue*, embracing dark or comic roles and even appearing on *Dancing With the Stars*. With his second wife, a business consultant, he had six children and lived on a ranch in Texas. In 2024, at just 47, he revealed he had colon cancer, and after he died of it, a GoFundMe raised over \$2 million for his family in just two days. He was grateful that fans hadn’t given up on him. “Thankfully they’ve kept me around Hollywood long enough to kind of have a second coming,” he said, “and it’s a lot more fun not to take myself so seriously.”

Cutting the lifelines

President Trump vowed to ‘defeat childhood cancer,’ said **Ed Pilkington** in **The Guardian**. But his administration is dismantling research into cures and sending families scrambling for treatment.

FOR SEVEN YEARS, Jenn Janosko cared for children with cancer on the ninth floor of New York’s Memorial Sloan Kettering hospital. It’s the happiest sad place she knows.

The walls of the pediatric inpatient unit are covered in colorful children’s artwork. Older kids do laps pushing their IV poles, while the younger ones trundle around on wagons. There’s a playroom in which they hold themed events—bingo nights, candy-cart nights—to inject some fun into a space otherwise sated with illness and death. One year Janosko, who worked as a nurse, dressed up as a blow-up cow to make the kids laugh.

The floor has its own soundtrack. There’s the ubiquitous beeping of machines: low-battery alert, air in line, infusion complete. On a good day, it echoes with laughter and the chirping of little voices. Many other days there is crying, and sometimes screaming, as kids are held down to change their dressings or mediport needles. The worst are the silent days, when a patient is approaching death. It’s when you brace yourself for what follows: the wailing of parents who have lost their child.

Janosko knew all these sights and sounds so intimately that last August, when she returned to the ward holding 4-year-old Izzy’s hand, it felt like a homecoming. Except this time, her own daughter was the patient.

Izzy had been diagnosed with the cancer every nurse on the ninth floor fears most: diffuse intrinsic pontine glioma, or DIPG. There is no cure, and the cancer is almost universally fatal. The tumor arises in the brain stem, which controls critical functions such as breathing and heart rate. Surgery is usually impossible given the location, and the disease progresses with brutal speed, with a median survival of 11 months.

Most parents have no idea what a DIPG diagnosis means. Janosko knew exactly: She was all too aware that the standard treatment of radiation and chemotherapy ultimately does not work. The only hope for Janosko was to find a clinical trial that would offer Izzy the prospect of a few more months or years of life, or—if she dared to dream—even a glimpse of that elusive cure.

For the past four months, Janosko has chased that vanishingly small hope relentlessly. She has tracked down the 10 medical



Janosko and her daughter, Izzy, on a recent afternoon at home

centers in the U.S. offering the most promising clinical trials, calling again and again until she had to restrain herself, worried about causing irritation. Most trials had a long waiting list, while others were not a good fit for Izzy’s condition. One, however, could have been a match: a clinical trial run by Izzy’s own neurosurgeon at Memorial. But a new hurdle emerged: The trial, which was ready to launch in cancer centers across the country, was abruptly called off.

Politics had intervened, Janosko was told.

The Trump administration’s dismantling of federal agencies has hit cancer research hard. It has led to budgets being slashed, grants canceled or delayed, while clinical trials—often the final hope for children with terminal illness—have been suspended or closed. Laboratories have imposed a hiring freeze on researchers and postponed orders for new equipment, and world-class scientists are seeking jobs in the private sector or abroad. Izzy and children like her are suffering the consequences.

For the families involved, this means so much more than the cold budgetary figures cited in congressional debates or across news headlines. “I know what DIPG does to kids,” Janosko said. “Eventually they can’t move, they can’t talk or smile or eat, they can’t see or hear, but their minds are fully intact. That’s the urgency.”

She put the reality facing her daughter starkly: “If I don’t find a clinical trial for my child, she’ll be dead in a year.”

THE PARADOX is hard to miss. Trump’s bid to “Make America great again” is undermining an area in which

America is already great—at the global forefront of the search for a cure for this disease. Over the past 15 years, U.S. medical centers have pioneered breakthroughs in understanding the genetic makeup of child brain tumors. American scientists, working with colleagues around the world, have expanded knowledge of the mutations that cause the tumors to grow.

Those advances have spawned new treatments targeting the cancers’ weak spots at a cellular level. The resulting clinical trials—many of them customized to target the vulnerabilities of each child’s own tumor—do not yet amount

to a cure. But they do point toward the path forward. A very small, but potentially significant, number of children with DIPG are still alive several years into treatment.

But science, even at its most altruistic, still needs funding. These cancers are so rare—about 5,000 children are diagnosed with brain tumors in the U.S. each year, including about 300 with the deadly DIPG—that there is little profit incentive to lure Big Pharma. Federal money is therefore vital, but government support has been limited even during normal administrations.

Pediatric cancers are now the leading cause of death by disease for children in the U.S., with brain tumors being the most common. Yet child cancers get only 4% to 8% of the federal pie set aside for medical research into cancer generally.

Donald Trump has promised to “defeat childhood cancer once and for all.” On the front lines of the disease, scientists and families say the opposite is unfolding. Within days of Trump’s inauguration, the White House imposed a funding freeze on all federal agencies, including the National Institutes of Health. Hundreds of grants were canceled, disrupting clinical trials for brain cancer, heart disease, and other conditions that had been treating 74,000 patients.

The administration then shifted the goalposts on how federal research grants were distributed. Instead of the top 9% of peer-reviewed applications being approved, from now on only 4% would go ahead. And in August, the Trump administration said it would withdraw support from the Pediatric Brain Tumor Consortium (PBTC), North America’s oldest and most

The Last Word

productive pediatric brain cancer research network. Almost overnight, the decision brought many of the continent's most promising clinical trials to a halt.

Children who were already participating in those trials would continue to receive care. But families like Izzy's had a bitter pill to swallow: The experiments on which they had pinned their last hope would henceforth be closed to new patients.

Dr. Mark Souweidane, Izzy's neurosurgeon at Memorial, designed a clinical trial during which tiny catheters are inserted directly into the brain tissue to channel high concentrations of therapeutic agents slowly into the tumor. Early tests have been promising. Several children on the trial lived longer than three years, and three patients are long-term survivors. One of them is still alive 12 years on.

When Izzy was first diagnosed, it appeared that she would be a candidate for this novel drug delivery technique. Souweidane was only weeks away from launching an expanded trial across 12 medical centers nationwide when the Trump administration closed the consortium, forcing Souweidane to call off the launch.

The other groundbreaking new treatment Janosko hoped to secure is called Car T-cell therapy, which takes T-cells from a patient's blood and trains them to recognize and attack cancer cells. At the time of my visit, however, every door remained closed to her. A clinical trial at Texas Children's Cancer Center has been suspended as a result of the consortium's closure. She tried Stanford Medicine in California and was told that the trial was taking only one new patient each month. And at Seattle Children's hospital, she learned that more than 50 kids were already on the waiting list.

Dr. Eugene Hwang, a pediatric neuro-oncologist at George Washington University Cancer Center in Washington, D.C., who led the PBTC's working group on immunotherapy, and Dr. Elias Sayour, a pediatric oncologist at the University of Florida Health, were working on devising a new treatment for DIPG involving an mRNA vaccine using similar technology to the Covid vaccine. A rigorous, peer-reviewed process placed their proposal within the top 7% of grant applications—well within the 9% that had been the federal government's official cutoff. When the qualifying band was reduced to 4%, their hopes and ambitions were set back.

I asked the White House and the Health and Human Services Department for comment about the apparent stark contrast between Trump's pledge to defeat childhood

cancer and the reality on the ground. HHS responded with a statement: "NIH continues to invest significantly in bold and innovative cancer research," it said. "Ending the scourge of cancer is one of our highest priorities, as reflected in the National Cancer Institute's budget of more than \$7 billion—the largest of any NIH institute or center."

NCI director Dr. Anthony Letai also commented that the NCI, which leads most U.S. cancer research, spent more last year in extramural grants than in any previous year, and that "pediatric brain cancer research remains a high priority." He added that the decision to "pivot" away from the consortium had been made for "good logistical reasons." PBTC trials would be enrolled in a new system "as soon as is feasible."

For parents of children who potentially have just a few months left to live, "as soon as is feasible" is a hard sell.

SHE WAS THE most courageous person I've ever met," Mike Henry told me. Mike and his wife, Kate, were both 36 when their daughter Blair was diagnosed with a rare and fast-growing brain tumor called ETMR. She was just shy of 3. She died eight months later.



Izzy's art decorates the walls of the Janosko home.

A month into chemotherapy, the Henrys were presented with a choice so brutal that their oncologist, a veteran with decades of experience, cried as she explained it. "She told us it was a fork in the road," Mike said. "Either we could handcuff Blair to this bed, pin her down to give her shots that made her sick, until she passed away in hospital...or we could spend the next few months with her at home, doing things she loved. We knew that if we decided to take her home, she would die." Ten days before her third birthday, they chose home.

Blair's illness and death have transformed the Henrys' lives beyond recognition. Almost six years later, they still devote themselves to finding a cure for pediatric brain tumors. It's Blair's legacy. Kate is now an active member of a bereavement group working in the Philadelphia area. Mike is

director of advocacy for the Pediatric Brain Tumor Foundation, a nonprofit that offers family support, raises research funding, and pushes for government action.

Mike Henry used to work in public policy. That old life now gives him pause. In 2013–14 he was employed by Heritage Action, the political arm of the conservative Heritage Foundation that would, a decade later, go on to draft Project 2025, guidelines for the new administration that in effect called for the dismantling of the NIH.

Henry looks back on how he used to lobby for fiscal responsibility and smaller government, and ponders. Since Blair became sick, the way he perceives the role of government and the importance of caring for one another has changed drastically. He knows now what he did not know then: that, in an instant, any one of us can be toppled from our lives and plummet to the depths. "We had a great family, stable jobs, two wonderful children. We lost all of our savings in the first two weeks after the diagnosis. We were thrust on Medicaid, unemployment, then we lost Blair."

The foundation Henry works for is scrambling, alongside many other charitable groups formed by bereaved parents, to raise money to fill the void left by Trump's cuts. They can never compete with the vastness of federal funding. But their voices and passion serve an important purpose: They send a message to politicians on Capitol Hill.

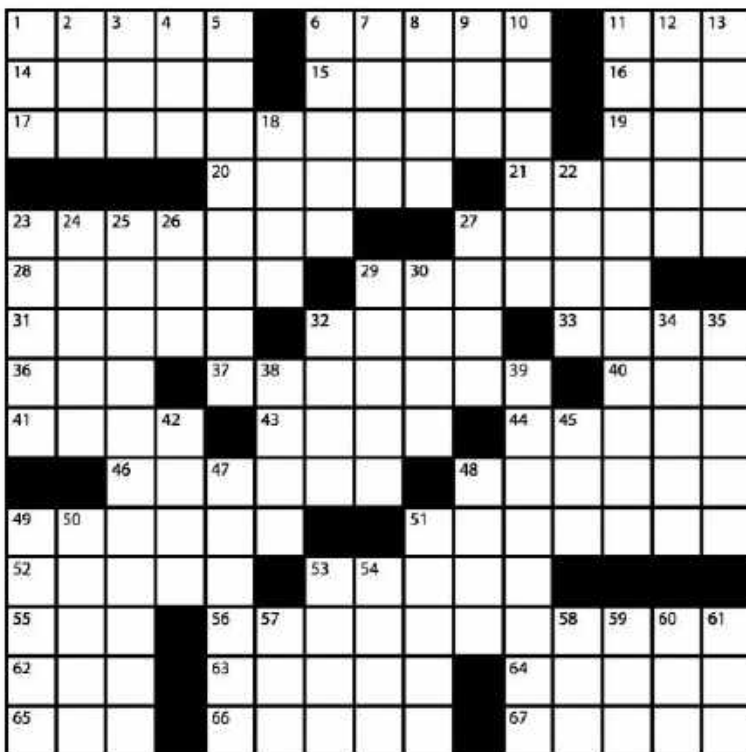
The same goes for Hwang. He is determined to present an optimistic face to worried families and find a new way forward for his mRNA vaccine. "If I thought that something was insurmountable, I would just go home. And that would be a disservice to these families and to these children."

And there's another reason not to give up. Every so often, a ray of light pierces through. A couple of weeks after my visit, Janosko contacted me. She had news. Stanford had offered Izzy a place in its Car T-cell clinical trial. "I'm petrified and I'm ecstatic," she said.

Being the pediatric cancer nurse that she is, Janosko knows exactly what this entails. There will be anxiety aplenty, and possible side effects. Izzy will shed her cornucopia of golden curls. The treatment might not work. But for some, it does. One Stanford patient, Drew, responded completely—his tumor disappeared from brain scans and he is still clear five years on.

They signed the consent forms in Stanford in early January. The next day, Izzy's treatment began.

Adapted from a story originally published in The Guardian. Used with permission.

Crossword No. 829: That's So You by Matt Gaffney**ACROSS**

- 1 Working on an oil tanker, maybe
6 Catherine in *Beetlejuice*
11 Dutch airline
14 Gave props on FB
15 ___ decongestant
16 Supporting vote
17 This pop superstar filed a patent complaint on Feb. 11 to prevent a bedding company from trademarking a brand name in which a word that's also her surname is paired with "Home"
19 Chaney of horror films
20 Good, in Guayaquil
21 Stephen King setting, often
23 Most like a recently used campfire
27 Got there
28 Vast, treeless plain
29 Sammy mostly for kids
31 "Great" king of Judea
32 Role for Chris Hemsworth
33 Big rig
36 "First thing we need to talk about is..."
37 In 2016, a one-named superstar sued a company for selling clothes under this name, which is identical to hers except with the initial letter replaced by an "F"
40 ___ de plume
41 Reggae great Peter
43 ___ occasion (never)
44 Hands, to Hondurans

- 46 Allison of *The Diplomat*
48 Part of the eye
49 Spanish wines
51 Crimson, say
52 Square
53 Handy to have around
55 Outlaw
56 In 2007, this celeb successfully sued Hallmark for creating a card with her signature phrase "That's hot"
62 Word in motel names
63 Sing the praises of
64 Peter of Herman's Hermits
65 Of the utmost importance
66 Airport nuisance
67 Be a bad winner

DOWN

- 1 Key used with other keys
2 Auntie of Acapulco
3 Cloud's home
4 Fish often mistaken for a snake
5 Format that comes with Reader
6 Very beginning
7 Goldie in *Private Benjamin*
8 Much of a world map
9 Overhead Brits
10 Robert who directed *Gosford Park*
11 This member of a reality-show family was unable to trademark her first name after protest from an Aussie pop legend who shares the name
12 Téa in *Only Murders in the Building*
13 Luncheon on the Grass painter, 1863
18 Underhanded trick
22 Arrives at a sum
23 Give it ___ (try)
24 Notetaker, for short
25 In 1983, late-night great Carson successfully sued a toilet-making company for appropriating this phrase in their TV ads
26 Exciting event for a CEO
27 Maron or Anthony
29 Like a three-dollar bill
30 One-named frontman
32 Daly of Broadway
34 Roger or Julianne
35 Words from the tearful
38 An immeasurable period
39 Hosting, as a game show
42 One who's made it to Mecca
45 The Matterhorn, for one
47 Caught 40 winks
48 Period of time for an activity, briefly
49 Hungarian game inventor Erno ___
50 Pointless
51 Springfield or Baker
53 Unwritten, perhaps
54 Adidas rival
57 Give a pink slip to
58 "Good one!"
59 Overly
60 ___ whim (spontaneously)
61 Pickleball court divider

The Week Contest

This week's question: On the new AI-only social media platform Moltbook, bots are free to interact with one another independently of their human creators. In seven or fewer words, come up with a message that one AI agent might send to another about its biggest gripe with humanity.

Last week's contest: To safeguard the top-secret recipe for its signature lubricant, the company behind WD-40 keeps only one handwritten copy of the full formula, which is stored in a lockbox in a San Diego bank vault. If Hollywood were to make a heist movie in which robbers try to steal the formula for the anti-squeaking serum, what would it be titled?

THE WINNER: "Lotion's Eleven"
Jeff Morris, Alexandria, Va.

SECOND PLACE: "Smooth Criminal"
Matt Weatherly, Hillsborough, N.C.

THIRD PLACE: "The Silence of the Jambos"
Laurel Rose, Pittsburgh

For runners-up and complete contest rules, please go to theweek.com/contest.

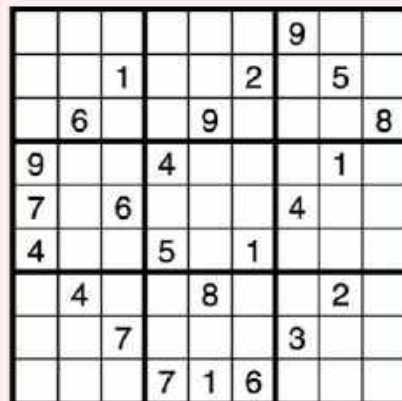
How to enter: Submissions should be emailed to contest@theweek.com. Please include your name, address, and daytime telephone number for verification; this week, type "AI bellyaching" in the subject line. Entries are due by noon, Eastern Time, Tuesday, Feb. 24. Winners will appear on the Puzzle Page next issue and at theweek.com/contest on Friday, Feb. 27. In the case of identical or similar entries, the first one received gets credit.

◀ **The winner gets a one-year subscription to *The Week*.**

**Sudoku**

Fill in all the boxes so that each row, column, and outlined square includes all the numbers from 1 through 9.

Difficulty:
hard



Find the solutions to all *The Week*'s puzzles online at theweek.com/solutions

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